His Veil of Sorrow, Hidden Behind That Bright Smile

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/64006336.

Rating:	Teen And Up Audiences
Archive Warnings:	Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	M/M
Fandom:	崩坏：星穹铁道 | Honkai: Star Rail (Video Game)
Relationship:	Mydei/Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail)
Characters:	Mydei (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Hyacine (Honkai: Star Rail)
Additional Tags:	Angst, Fluff and Angst, 5+1 Things, Pre-Amphoreus Trailblaze Missions (Honkai: Star Rail), Established Relationship, Platonic Relationships, well not really established but you get the idea, Teasing, Banter, Phainon Needs a Hug (Honkai: Star Rail), no beta we die like trianne, Hurt/Comfort, Hyacine and Mydei are good ol' buddies and you can't tell me otherwise, Hugs, Fluff, Mentioned Aglaea (Honkai: Star Rail), Original Character(s), Minor Original Character(s), The Black Tide (Honkai: Star Rail), ok this needs it's own tag, Holding Hands, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Fluff and Hurt/Comfort, Mentioned Tribbie (Honkai: Star Rail), Mentioned Cyrene (Honkai: Star Rail), Mydei-centric (Honkai: Star Rail), POV Alternating, in the last chapter, Mentioned Trailblazer (Honkai: Star Rail), Mentioned Caelus (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon is Flame Reaver (Honkai: Star Rail), Bittersweet Ending, I'M SO SORRY FOR THAT ENDING AHHHHHHH, now with bonus chapters!, IT'S FINALLY FINISHED, Mentioned Anaxa (Honkai: Star Rail), Idiots in Love
Language:	English
Stats:	Published: 2025-03-20 Completed: 2025-05-16 Words: 22,196 Chapters: 10/10

His Veil of Sorrow, Hidden Behind That Bright Smile

by AnodeAntarcSkywalker

Summary

Phainon was a person who smiled a lot, that much everyone in the Holy City knew.

However, whether those smiles were real or not, no one could know. After all, he was shrouded in mystery. No one knows where he came from or how he arrived at Okhema. To the people's knowledge, he's been here for a long time. Time has passed. New generations of Okhemans are now living their carefree lives, playing all sorts of games with their friends. People have come and gone, some friends and others strangers. The new tomorrow was near the horizon.

If only the Deliverer could feel happy about it.

Or, 5 times Mydei made Phainon (genuinely) smile (because he has that effect on him, *and* make him all flustered) and the one time he made him cry.

(NOW WITH BONUS CHAPTERS!)

Notes

So....this isn't the first time I'm writing a 5+1 fic and it's DEFFO NOT THE LAST! I think I need help-

ANYWAYS I'm going to try and make all 6 of these one-shots flow into a cohesive story. Let's see where this takes us. I hope you guys will love to come on this little journey! ❤️

Enjoy!!!

Chapter 1

Phainon was a person who smiled a lot, that much everyone in the Holy City knew.

He wasn't just a Chrysos Heir on the path of the Flame-Chase. Nor was he the Deliverer (as a certain prince would call him almost all the time) that was destined to witness the new tomorrow alone. He mingled with the townsfolk easily. Well, Lady Tribios as well (Aglaea was slowly losing her divinity-she's at the stage where she doesn't even know how to talk to children anymore, Castorice had to stay 3 feet away from the population and Mydei…well no explanation was needed there), but there was something about those striking blue eyes and snowy white hair that seems to draw everyone in.

However, whether those smiles were real or not, no one could know. After all, he was shrouded in mystery. No one knows where he came from or how he arrived at Okhema. To the people's knowledge, he's been here long. Time has passed. New generations of Okhemans are now living their carefree lives, playing all sorts of games with their friends. People have come and gone, some friends and others strangers. The new tomorrow was near the horizon.

If only the Boy Saviour could feel happy about it.

“Watch it, Deliverer!” Mydei hissed, jumping to the left as a stray arrow nearly sliced his shoulder. Phainon gave him an apologetic look before grabbing another arrow from the quiver and nocking it carefully. The prince sighed and made his way to his side.

Thankfully, the training grounds were empty, and Mydeimos was glad he had the foresight to clear the area before he and Phainon worked on the Deliverer's archery skills. Which wasn't going…so well, as evidenced by the fact he almost pierced his heart. Not that he was worried or anything, but he *really* wasn't in the mood to be sent to Thanatos’ embrace and come back to life.

Phainon had his tongue stuck out, eyes scrunched as he focused on nocking the arrow to the bow... and failing miserably. Oh, Titans.

This was wonderful. This was fine. *Fine.* It could be worse.

Mydei *tsked* in disapproval and flexed his fingers, resisting the massive urge to pinch his nose and sigh. The man thankfully took the hint and handed the bow. “Too slow there, dear Deliverer, the enemy would have killed you ten times over. You need to be faster in getting your weapon ready.”

“Hey!” Phainon huffed, puffing his cheeks and folding his arms. “We've only been at this thrice. I can't become an expert overnight. Have some patience, Mydei.”

‘If only someone could give some to me,’ Mydei thought grimly. Then again, this whole thing was *his* idea, wasn't it?

Phainon was good with a sword and greatsword. He was one of the best, keeping up with him in a fight. The way he swung his weapon with deadly precision and blocked most blows that would've shattered an ordinary person's arms. But when it came to using long-range gear, his eyesight suddenly decided not to work. At least that's what Mydei thinks.

He couldn't always rely on his sword. Sure it was forged by Chartonus to ensure it never gets destroyed in battle, but what if he loses it at some point? Of course, the possibility of that was very low, but it wasn't zero. Learning a wide array of weapons is always good for improving one's skills and guaranteeing survival on the field.

Mydei mostly fought with his fists, using his gauntlets to punch a hole in the enemy, and he usually never found himself using anything else. However, his mother taught him the ways of the blade and archery, and when things looked desperate he'd grab the nearest weapon and use it. The Kremnoan Detachment largely used swords and shields and preferred to use *only* those. He knows he can't make them change their mind, and everyone knows who the Prophecy is referring to. *'The one who will get to see the new tomorrow.'*

But this was proving to be more difficult than he previously thought.

Mydei handed the bow back to Phainon. "There you go. Now try to hit the target in front of you and not me. I don't want to die again after yesterday's skirmish."

"Aye aye teach!" Phainon replied, giving him a mock salute and a wink. Mydei merely glared at him and rolled his eyes. He heard a soft peal of laughter before the swordsman positioned his arms properly and drew the arrow back, one eye closed. At least he managed to nail that consistently.

"Remember," Mydei started to say, standing behind him, "relax your muscles and calm down. You're not surrounded by enemies. You're only training and therefore, you don't need to be tense."

"Kind of hard not to be," Phainon whispered. "I've messed this up way too many times for my liking."

"Doesn't everyone make mistakes?"

"Does everyone have the time to be here teaching?"

Ah. Mydei shook his head. Yes, he had things to do, and he had a squad to lead in two days with Hyacine to check up on some scholars and warriors who were stationed in a place that he doesn't quite remember (though it was somewhere beyond the Grove and Hyacine knows where, and Mydei trusts her judgment), so he should be preparing for that. All in all, his schedule was *packed*.

Yet, he still made room for this because he wanted the other Heirs to broaden their horizons when it came to battle tactics and, subsequently, their methods of fighting. Mydei does agree with Aglaea's methods most of the time, and she does acknowledge that brute strength is the solution to half of their problems, but…

Well, deep down he knew- *everyone* knew- he wasn't going to be in Okhema forever. He and his people were here as refugees. But one day the Kremnoans would have to return home to fight the perilous Black Tide. Nikador would have to be dealt with, and the Coreflame would have to be retrieved. And once that's done he'll have to follow the prophecy and start *his* Flame-Chase journey. And until then, he wanted Okhema to be prepared. He wanted his friend to be prepared. That's why he was doing this.

He wasn't going to say that *out loud* though.

"Well, I have the time now," Mydei said instead, wincing at how harsh his words came out. Phainon, thankfully, looked undeterred. He silently hoped he hadn't kept the man waiting for so long with his internal monologue- now how embarrassing would that be? "And you aren't the only person I'm teaching this to, Deliverer. You just happened to be my first victim."

Phainon laughed again, this time sounding brighter than before. Now *that* sounded much better. Lowering his arms, he teased, "Come on now, Mydeimos, you and I know the truth. Who are you trying to lie to? Yourself? There's no one here to pretend to."

"It's called *dignity*, dear Phainon," Mydei hissed and grabbed his arms and raised them again. "And just because I chased everyone away won't stop one random fool from waltzing in here. And you know I can't lock the doors."

"Because *that* would look suspicious."

"Phainon–!"

"🎶No matter how much you may think it, you can't kill me 🎶"

…That was infuriatingly true. Mydei groaned when he taunted him with his stupid sing-song voice. He twisted Phainon's arms, ignoring the surprised yelp that came out of his mouth, and pointed him to the target. "Let the arrow fly."

"Er, you sure?"

"Trust me," Mydei smirked. "I'd never waste a precious arrow. Now let it go."

And Phainon did just that. After Mydei took a step back, he released his hold on the shaft and cried out in joy when it made its mark right at the center. The prince felt his smirk grow wider.

He turned his head to look at him. "So, you think you can hit the spot on your own now?"

"I mean…wait what am I saying? Of course, I can!" Phainon exclaimed, blue eyes shining in determination as he grabbed another arrow and nocked it as fast as he could. Mydei peered over his shoulder and was satisfied that it didn't almost fall through his fingers this time. He straightened his back, pulled the string back, and planted his feet firmly onto the ground. He kept his hand steady, one eye closed, and took a deep breath. Mydei raised a brow, relieved that the idiot was *finally* easing up a little, and took a step forward. He didn't say anything, but nothing needed to be said.

And, a few seconds later, Phainon let the arrow soar…

Right into the middle.

Silence. Then…

“BULLSEYE!!!!!!!!”

Phainon pumped his fists into the air, laughing so hard he nearly fell to the ground, had it not been for Mydei to catch him at the nick of time. He couldn’t bring himself to be mad at the egghead for screaming like that. Those cheerful-sounding giggles were infectious– even Mydei himself wasn’t fully immune to it. He doubted he ever would be. He still scolded him though.

“Be a little more careful, would you? I’m not going to be here for a week, and I’d hate to find your dead body here when I return.”

“Oh, me- my- Mydei,” Phainon gasped between laughs, his chest rising and falling rapidly, “Yo-you re-a-lly thin-k I’m gon-n-a die *th-at* eas..eas-i-ly?”

“From the way you look, yes. You’re going to choke on your spit if you don’t quit it right now.”

“We-well, good luck try-na…st–op me!”

Mydei sighed loudly. There was no way he was going to stop him, and if he wanted to try, he’d be subjected to his flailing limbs smacking him everywhere. It’s better to let it run its course.

It only took a mere five minutes before the laughter died out, replaced by him heaving, stray giggles escaping his mouth once in a while. And all the while Mydei’s eyes never left him. After all, how could they? It was like he thought earlier-Phainon’s joy was contagious to anyone.

But what he didn’t expect was that small, crooked smile to appear on his face as he stared at him from the ground. That smile that he saw him rarely wear. The smile, dare he say, was reserved only for him. It was that kind of smile you would know was genuine and not a mask to hide anything. It was *raw*, real, and it was no secret that Phainon was a man who wore his heart on his sleeve. He sucked in a sharp breath the moment he laid eyes on it.

Phainon raised a hand, and Mydei took it, helping him up to his feet. They didn’t let go, and ‘Snowy’ squeezed his palm carefully. “Thanks, Mydei. I…didn’t think I’d ever need to learn to use other weapons. I’m so used to using my sword all the time, it never crossed my mind that I might not have it on me all the time. And I’m still learning to use my fists,” he joked at the end.

“And that’s why I always tell you that gauntlets are far superior than any other weapon,” Mydei retorted, punching him in the chest. “And that’s also why I tell you to wear the

training ones that Chartonus made for you before you decide to have a fistfight with me. You know mine are sharp."

"Yeah, yeah, next time I will."

"We'll see about that."

"Now, don't you have troops to prepare and a certain healer to talk to?"

"Dodging the claims, are we?"

"Not at all. Just reminding you that you have your hands full, and the Curtain-Fall Hour is nearly upon us."

"...Shit," Mydei nearly yelled, checking the time on the wall. Sure enough, it was nearing six, and he promised Hyacine he'd meet her at 6:10. She was waiting for him at the market. Well, there was no time to lose now, was there?

Phainon chuckled upon seeing his face and nudged him gently. "Go. I'll take care of cleaning up. I owe you one for taking your time to teach me."

That was all the confirmation Mydei needed before taking off. The *"Stay safe!"* doesn't go unheard either.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

> Ik this chapter has less phaidei content but JAKFKKDSK I KINDA NEEDED AN EXCUSE TO WRITE HYACINE Anyways her and Mydei are brother and sister your honor.
>
> Next chapter might be on the shorter side
> Also sorry for the Hyacine angst (AND HER DRIP MARKETING IS ALSO OUT TODAYYYYYY)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The scouting mission took a lot out of Mydei. Never in his immortal life has he ever felt so tired after one battle. And it wasn't just him feeling those effects either.

The Black Tide. Everyone in Amphoreus knew of its existence. It corrupted the minds of the people, driving them mad to the point of insanity. Once it digs its ugly claws into your brain and stays there for a long period of time, there's no coming back. That's what he, Hyacine and the soldiers were up against.

They had to slay their comrades. Their friends. The people that they've known for years.

He witnessed countless men kill the people they love, holding them in their arms until Death took them away. He saw the fear in his people's eyes, despite war being a familiar song to them. The worst was Hyacine. The poor girl was doing her best to heal everyone, both friend and foe, and Mydei saw how it was draining her. He had to drag her out of there before she was exhausted both physically and mentally. Almost all the scholars didn't make it…

They were making their way back to Okhema with the survivors-it wasn't the best idea to go to the Grove just yet, though Mydei had sent a messenger to tell Anaxa what happened, and to tell him Hyacine was safe. The light rays were gently piercing the inky black sky, which meant they were close to the Holy City. They set up camp for now and he was sitting on the log while the others rested in the makeshift tents. They all deserved it after the horrors they witnessed.

Mydei stoked the fire with the stick, his mind wandering to the battle. He fought the Black Tide before, when he and the detachment journeyed out of Castrum Kremnos after his father's death. Aglaea has sent him and Phainon to ward it off several times. He was no stranger to it. But today was different. Those people were mad, but their bodies didn't bear the signs of corruption. They never got the chance to fully transform because they arrived early. Hearing the sound of blood squirting out of their wounds and the smell of burnt human flesh was…it was *sickening* .

He has no doubt that Aglaea now knows of what happened. He'll still have to tell her about it, but at least he could leave out the gory details. The fact that he himself is feeling queasy, and he's the Crowned Prince of a civilization that was bathed in blood and honor is saying a lot. He's grateful they didn't lose anyone in his squad today. He already had to be the bearer of bad news and tell the families that their son or daughter was forever lost to the Black Tide.

Mydei sighed and took a bite of his pomegranate. He was going to stoke the fire again when he heard the rustling of fabric and saw cotton candy pink hair and bright turquoise eyes pop outside of a tent. A second later Hyacine crawled outside and stood up, tilting her head at him, those eyes glittering in the light and her arms clenched by her sides. *'Oh, Hyacine,'* he thought.

He didn't have to say anything. He gestured for her to come with his hand, and that's all she needed before she all but ran towards his side, sitting down and bringing her legs up to bury her face between them, letting out tiny sobs that Mydei had no doubt she had been suppressing for so long. He placed his hand on her shoulder and squeezed it. Thankfully, he didn't have his gauntlets on, lest he accidentally tear a small piece of fabric with those sharp claws. "Hyacine…"

"They're dead," Hyacine wailed, sniffing and wiping her eyes. "All of them are gone 'De, and I couldn't save them. No matter what I did or tried to do, I couldn't get the effects of the Tide out of them."

"Not everyone can be saved, especially those who are consumed by the Black Tide and you know it. But don't let today make you underestimate your abilities as a healer."

"But those men could've been ***saved*** *!"* yelled Hyacine, finally looking at him with tears streaming down her eyes. They were red and puffy from crying earlier. Now that Mydei took a good look at her, he saw just how messed up she was right now. Her bright pink hair looked dull even in the warm light of the fire and sticking up in all directions, her clothes were disheveled (and Mydei was well aware that she loved to keep all her clothes *including* pajamas ironed and pressed), and right now she was breaking down right under his arm.

But, what did she mean by when she said those men could've been saved?

"The Black Tide hadn't fully taken them away," Hyacine started to say softly, and Mydei had to strain his ears to hear what she was saying. "They had only been affected for a mere five minutes. There was enough time to bring them out of its influence. But…for some unexplained reason the tide was acting like a parasite-well, it *is* one but it somehow managed to take root in their minds and bodies so fast, they didn't have time to transform. That's why when we fought them they looked like their actual selves. The Black Tide has become more relentless, and I…"

She placed a hand over her mouth. "I saw it happen to someone I know. A fellow scholar that I'm good friends with. Her name was Lydia, a smart bird as everyone called her. She always helped out the younger students, and even came to aid me several times at the Twilight Courtyard. She…she begged me to kill her, saying that she didn't want to hurt anyone. I told her to quit it and let me save her, and as I focused on healing her wounds, I hadn't noticed that she stole the knife from the nurse near me and before I knew it, she… *she*... "

Hyacine's fingers were wrapped tightly around her pant leg, turning her knuckles red. Mydei gently pried them off. He was at a loss for words. What should he say? What *could* he say? No words of comfort would be able to heal the wound that was inside her right now. Losing a best friend…it'll hurt. It'll hurt so bad, sometimes even driving you to the brink of insanity.

Mydei wrapped his arm around her shivering frame and pulled her into a side hug, and almost immediately she buried her head into the soft fabric. He exhaled slowly, rubbing her arm gently. "Hyacine, I know it hurts. It hurts more than we ever realize. But I need you to listen to me."

He waited for a response, and when he felt that tiny head nod against his body, he continued to talk. "I've lost many of my closest friends before I arrived at Okhema. These five people helped me take my revenge against my father and lead the Kremnoan Detachment to the Holy City. Along the way, they died. One by one, they dropped like flies. When my last friend perished -the person whom I considered as a brother-I felt the world stop. I felt like the wind was sucked out of my lungs."

Mydei closed his eyes, those memories he buried deep in his mind rising to the surface. *Hephaestion, Perdikkas, Leonnius, Ptolemy, Peucesta.* He vowed that their names would never be forgotten by history. So long as he lives, the people who sacrificed themselves will always be remembered. His friends would always be remembered by him. It wasn't fair that fate took them all away from him. That one thought had plagued his mind over and over again, especially once Hephaestion died. That was the day he lost everything. He was at his lowest point after that. But he kept pushing forward for their sakes. He didn't want their deaths to be in vain. That one thought pierced through the dark fog in his mind. It still hurts, even to this day, but as long as he never forgot and honored them every day, that was enough.

"It took me a while to recover from the aftershock of everything, but once I did, I reminded myself that they weren't truly dead. A person only dies once their name is no longer uttered in this world. If there are people who can carry on their legacy, they will live on, even if they are now with Thanatos. Lydia will live in your heart, and she will be remembered by her friends. By *you*, her close friend. Grief is a fickle thing, and it always feels like someone is prying your heart out of your chest. Those wounds take time to heal, and sometimes they may never."

"I know," Hyacine whispered. "It…wouldn't be the first time. But, when I find myself like this, I wonder, how long will I be like this? How long will the pain and agony stay inside and eat me up before I'm back on my feet?"

"There's no answer to that," Mydei replied, staring at the fire. "Some heal faster than others. Some may heal completely. Others will have the scars lingering in their hearts. But no matter the case, healing isn't a linear process. There's no definitive time, and that's ok. What matters is that during that time you never forget them, and hold onto the memories you've made over the years, whether they be good or bad."

Hyacine let out a tiny giggle, scooting back a little to look at him. "I never knew the Crown Prince of Kremnos was a wise guy. Ahhhh, not that I'm saying Kremnoans aren't wise! Er, wait, what am I saying? I'm so sorry! I'm not trying to offend you or anything, De-!"

Mydei laughed. “Calm down,” he said, ruffling her hair. “I’m not offended in any way. Well, if it were Phainon then yes, but not you.”

She laughed again. “You and Phainon really like each other, huh?”

“He can keep up with me in battle and we have each other’s back, that’s all.”

“That’s all?”

“You’ve gotten more bold, haven’t you?” Mydei smirked. Hyacine merely rolled her red eyes. “A few months ago you wouldn’t have said anything.”

“I learn from the best.”

“Anaxa?”

“Both of you.”

Mydei chuckled and grabbed the stick to stoke the fire. They stayed silent, save for Hyacine’s occasional sniffling and tiny sobs. Only time could heal those scars now, and he hoped he got to her.

He heard her yawn and saw her eyes droop. Laughing quietly, he pulled her into a more comfortable position and let her head rest on his side. “Sleep,” Mydei said. “You’re tired. It couldn’t have been easy, healing everyone. Close your eyes and rest.”

“Will you be here?” Hyacine said in a low voice. “Until it is day break?”

Mydei cracked one of his rare smiles. “Of course.”

And sleep Hyacine did. The smile never left his face even after she was out like a light, and he grabbed another pomegranate from the bag. *Hephaestion, Perdikkas, Leonnius, Ptolemy, Peucesta.*

Even after he is long gone, they will be recorded in the history books and stored within the libraries of Castrum Kremnos. At least, the will once the city is no longer covered in ruins. His heart warmed at the thought. He took one more glance at Hyacine and shook his head- It appeared his words did not just comfort the healer.

Finally, *finally* they were back in Okhema. The sun greeted them as the Entry Hour had started, and everyone was relieved to be back home.

They took the back route to avoid the people at the market. No one had the heart to break the news to anyone just yet, Mydei included, and Aglaea thankfully agreed with the sentiment. Furthermore, she reassured him that she’d tell the families herself with Anaxa and told him to go rest.

So, he dropped Hyacine to her room (“No, you can fuss over me and the others *later* once you’ve rested,” he told her when she looked hesitant. “Let your assistants handle everything

for once. That's why you have them, right?) and made his way to the kitchen. So what if he was bone-tired and felt like collapsing on his bed? Mydei loved pomegranates to death, but that sure wasn't enough to stave off the hunger. He needed a proper meal.

Mydei opened the doors, mentally going through his list of foods he could make without consuming so much time when he noticed two things. Two really strange things. One could even say he witnessed a paradox at that very moment.

On the table was a plate. A plate that held a stack of blueberry pancakes topped with strawberries, syrup and a bit of whipped cream. He knew the plate was for him because it was placed in the corner where he usually sat when he and the other Chrysos Heirs ate their meals together. It was usually Mydei who cooked for the others, so it was a bit surprising to find breakfast waiting for him on the table.

But what surprised him the most was the person behind the stove, humming a tune under his breath and bouncing under his feet. The man whom everyone knew couldn't cook. The man who almost *burned down this very kitchen the last time he tried.*

"Phainon?!"

The man yelped, nearly tossing the pan in his hand and held it out like a weapon, pointing it menacingly at the intruder who dared make their way to the Heir's private room. Mydei raised a brow and scoffed when he saw the man look surprised…and a little sheepish, like he wasn't expecting him to come back so early.

"Ahhhhhh….Mydei!" Phainon exclaimed, turning off the stove and grabbing another plate stacked with pancakes-this time strawberry with little blueberries and peaches scattered on the top with a small slice of butter, syrup and cream-and setting it on the table. "What-what a surprise! I wasn't expecting you to arrive back here this early. Aglaea told me you'd be here at around 10:00."

"Well, here I am now," Mydei said drily, taking his seat. He inspected every inch and corner of his pancake and was satisfied-and impressed, *very* impressed that there wasn't a single cake that was burnt. "How many tries did this take you?"

"Three," Phainon chirped happily and slid into the seat opposite to him. "I followed your recipe to a tea, and the first two times the batter came out a little too watery, and the third was way too thick. I just used some milk to loosen it a little and voila. The others said they were going to eat a little late, and since I was hungry and heard you guys were coming today, I figured I'd surprise you."

Mydei started to remove his gauntlets. "Well, I'll have to admit that you did, Deliverer. This is actually quite a nice surprise."

"I'm glad you like it. And, uhm…I don't know if you want to talk about…it, but I heard what…happened."

"Aglaea?"

“Yeah. Poor Hyacine,” Phainon said sadly. “She got overwhelmed fast. I can’t blame her for it. Even the most seasoned warriors would’ve faltered that day. Even experienced healers such as herself.”

“She’s still young,” said Mydei, cutting into his breakfast and taking a bite. Light, fluffy and airy with rich flavors. Was this the same Phainon who burnt an *omelet* two weeks ago? How did he become a master chef so fast? He figured he’d ask him later. “It took me a bit of convincing to get her to rest and let the other healers take over. She needed a mental break more than a physical one.”

He was glad no one knew of her breakdown-that was their little secret.

“I’ll go visit her later once she’s rested,” Phainon said, and reached to hold Mydei’s arm. “I can imagine it mustn't have been easy for you as well. You’re going to rest after eating, right?”

“I don’t have anything else to do, other than visit the infirmary later for a checkup, but that’s after Hyacine wakes up. So yes, I’ll take a nap and wake up for lunch.”

“That’s good.” Phainon shot him a smile-that *damn, heart melting smile* that always made him feel…something. Does the Deliverer know that has an effect him? “I can see it affected you a bit as well. I know Hyacine looks up to you in her own way, and I’m…thankful that you were there for her.”

“There’s no need for that,” Mydei sighed, taking another bite of his pancakes. Their hands stayed entwined on the table. “I did what I had to do, and the girl desperately needed someone to talk to and some shut-eyes.”

“‘I did what I had to do.’ Sure, keep telling me and yourself that.”

“Shut up before I punch you, Deliverer.”

“You wouldn’t dare 🎶.”

“...Shut up and finish eating. We’ll settle this on the training field later.”

“Oooh, is that a challenge? Also, how am I supposed to eat with my mouth shut?”

“Phainon of Aedes Elysiae-”

“Relax!” Phainon laughed, squeezing his hand. “You know I’m just teasing you. You’re more tired than I thought. Eat and rest, and then in the evening we’ll have a small spar after your check up. That sound good?”

And oh, it does.

Chapter End Notes

Phainon really does suffer from the Kaslana curse of not being able to cook anything😔 (except if he *really* tries.)

Next chapter is halfway done!

26-03-2025: Fixed some mistakes in chapters one and two! (Google docs really screwed me over here with all the commas 😭😭)

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

So I said this chapter was gonna be on the shorter side...heh. Eheheh.

I'm still brainstorming an idea for the next chapter and it's gonna be delayed cause I got a really bad cold 🤧. But hey, MORE PHAIDEI CONTENT!!!

I fixed up any errors that may be there, but I will double-check once more in the morning

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“How… many Titankin have… you slayed?”

“78. You?”

“...65.”

“Looks like you’re losing your touch, Deliverer,” Mydei smirked, wiping the blood smeared across his face. Beside him, Phainon shot him a half-hearted glare, panting heavily. The smirk only grew on his face.

The abominations came out of nowhere near the outskirts of Aidonia, and it was only thanks to Aglaea’s golden threads that she was able to identify the sudden threat and dispatch him and the Deliverer to deal with it. They were quite far away from Okhema, so they would have reached the Holy City in about three days. It was thanks to Lady Trianne's Century Gate that they were able to arrive in time. It was always better to deal with the problem before it became a major problem.

At first, the duo thought they alone would be enough to deal with them, and they still did.

However, they were so close to giving up.

They split up to cover more ground. They were Okhema’s strongest warriors- they could handle battling a small army on their own if they wanted to. It was Mydei this time who challenged Phainon, and the latter gladly accepted, that familiar fire burning in those azure blue eyes. Now, he was almost- *almost* regretting the whole thing. Regretting it because, while their intel was right and there were monsters almost everywhere, they never, in a million years, expected a whole ass army of them! An army that could rival in size Castrum Kremnos’ Elite Guard!

They severely underestimated the number of Titankin. Splitting up was the right call to make to deal with the two waves that were coming at them, but even then, there were a lot of them

that, at one point, Mydei thought it would've been a little nicer if they had brought a few soldiers with them. He wasn't sure how well Phainon was faring in this mess. They agreed to meet at the center of the courtyard once they'd all been taken care of. Mydei was the last to arrive, and he saw Phainon sitting down on the steps, slumped over, his greatsword planted into the ground. His eyes were closed. Mydei nudged him gently to get his attention.

After Phainon had woken up ("I wasn't sleeping! Just resting my eyes is all.") they were wondering what the fuck was really going on. The Titankin weren't intelligent creatures- they were built for was to destroy whatever was in their path. Also, from the way they were fighting, it looked like they knew they were going to come. They were anticipating their arrival. Mydei was about to voice out this theory when he saw something that made his blood turn cold.

Now, Mydei bore several scratches on his arms and chest, but those would heal themselves in a few minutes. Nothing that his curse couldn't fix. Phainon, on the other hand, looked like he went to the forest to maul a bear. His head hung low, and he was breathing laboriously. His sleeves were torn and bloodied, and he had a huge gash across his left cheek, nearly reaching his eye. Dirt covered his cape and boots, and…

Was that a…was that a *stab wound* on his *stomach!?*

"Deliverer!" Mydei nearly yelled, hovering over him. With the way Phainon was hunched over, he didn't notice his blood-soaked shirt until he shifted a bit to the side to reveal a huge gash across his stomach. And, *oh, that was quite a bit of blood.*

At once, he forced the other to lie down (thankfully without much complaining, except for a little whine that he paid no mind to) and carefully tore the fabric to inspect the wound. Titan's above, he should've seen this coming! The way he was breathing, the sweat covering his forehead, and his *fucking posture of all things!* Did the man have some sort of death wish?

"Are you an idiot?" Mydei snarled, ripping some fabric from his cape and wrapping it around the wound to staunch the bleeding. It didn't look like the cut was deep, but he wasn't a healer. All he knew was basic first aid, and that wasn't going to help him now with all that golden blood spilled everywhere. "Phainon, *answer me!* Why didn't you say anything before you little HKS!?"

"I…I thought," Phainon rasped, wincing when Mydei tied the fabric securely to the gash. "I thought I could…handle it. I…didn't want to m…make you wor..ry."

"Well, didn't that work out well!?" roared Mydei. This…this *manchild* actually thought hiding a cut that large that could be fatal was a good idea? Because he didn't want to worry anyone? Then it dawned upon him, and a strong wave of anxiety washed over him. He had no idea how long Phainon had been waiting for him. He had no idea how long he had been bleeding for.

Oh, *fuck*. "When we get back to Okhema, I'm going to make sure I end you myself after you're healed, bring you back from Thanatos' embrace and kill you again."

Phainon laughed, spitting blood everywhere. "Now is–n't that a…bit of a-an over-k-ill?"

“Not in my eyes. If you had said something earlier, we could’ve made it back to the city. Instead you made me talk about the fucking *Titankin!* ”

Mydei was mad. Furious. Livid. *Everything* . But years of practice had helped him rein in that anger and channel it into something more productive. Right now, screaming at Phainon wasn’t going to help anyone. Getting him back to Okhema was his first priority, and he hoped Hyacine had had enough rest to treat him.

Phainon wheezed, grabbing Mydei’s forearm with such strength it startled him for a second, “Geez, you-you’re no fun, aren’-aren’t ya?”

“Save your breath,” Mydei hissed. “Focus on staying alive. You’ll have the time to yap all you want once you’re healed.”

“I-I don't…yap *that* mu..ch.”

The blood soaked almost completely through the fabric, and Mydei sucked in a sharp breath. He had to get him out of here, and fast. “Phainon, I'm going to carry you back to the city, and until we get there do *not* close your eyes. Do you understand me?”

“I..don't know,” Phainon gasped and let out a tiny cry when Mydei secured another piece of fabric to his abdomen. “I..uh, My-dei?”

“What did I say about talking?”

“I…I th-think I mig-might…pass out.”

“...WHAT!? Goddamnit, Phainon, stay with me! Don’t you dare close your eyes!” Mydei got up and carefully hoisted the swordsman into his arms, being careful not to accidentally scratch him with his gauntlets. Making sure he had a good grip on him, he grabbed Phainon’s greatsword, tossed it behind his shoulder, and yelled for a Century Gate, ignoring the blood that was splattered everywhere on his body.

“He’s going to be alright, De,” Hyacine said, double-checking the gauze wrapped tightly around Phainon’s torso and patted his arm. “You know he’s been through worse.”

“That doesn’t make it any better,” Mydei replied, his eyes never leaving Phainon’s sleeping form. After he brought him back, he went to his room to take a bath (under Hyacine’s orders- he didn't want to leave his side, but she wouldn't let him near the man until he had cleaned up..) “He didn’t say a word about it. Not even a single word, and we counted the number of Titankin we took down. He even laughed, Hyacine! And when I asked him why, he said he, and I quote, *‘I thought I could handle it. It wasn’t a huge wound, so I assumed I could walk it off.’* ”

Ok, so those weren’t his exact words, but that was what he said!

“That…does sound like Phainon alright,” said Hyacine, letting out a sigh. “Regardless, I’ve done everything I can for him. He should wake up in an hour or two, but I can’t guarantee

that. He…he lost quite a bit of blood. If you hadn't managed to staunch the bleeding in time…"

Mydei shuddered. That was one thought he did *not* want to think about. Phainon was safe, and that was all that mattered.

"I'll write up a report to Lady Aglaea," Hyacine continued to say, summoning her pen and pad. "I'm pretty sure she'll want to know how our Deliverer is faring, and I'll bring his medicine and some herbs to help replenish his fluids. I also have some other patients to tend to, so it'll take me a while to get back here. In the meantime, can I entrust you to look after him?"

"Of course," he instantly replied.

"Thank you. Oh, and do remember to call me if anything happens, though I doubt anything would. He's well past the danger zone. Thank you once again, De." And with that, she made her way out of the room, but not before he called out to her.

"Is something wrong?"

"No, just…I told you rest was the key now, didn't I?"

Hyacine stared at him, dumbfounded for a few seconds before giggling. "It sure was! I think you should open a clinic here for the Chrysos Heirs. You're really good at listening and giving out advice. You might even make quite a bit of money, not that you need it, considering you're a prince."

"A prince of a nation that is now in ruins and is somewhere in Amphoreus," Mydei said drily. "Plus, I have my own duties here, remember?"

"Yeah, yeah, I know De, just pulling your leg is all. Alright then, I'll see you later."

Once Hyacine was out of the room, did Mydei truly let himself relax. He unfolded his arms, grabbed the chair nearby and a book Hyacine had left for him, and sat down beside the bed. Phainon was still unconscious, and Hyacine did say it'd take around an hour for him to wake up…

Stealing a glance at the clock, Mydei sighed. He had time to kill, he might as well read the book- something about Mnestia and Cerces' relationship and wait for the Boy Saviour to open his eyes.

And so, he waited.

And waited…

….

….

…….

This was going to take forever, wasn't it?

Mydei groaned, setting the book on his lap and buried his face into his arms. If Phainon were awake he'd be teasing him like hell. *"What? Does the Crown Prince need teaching on patience? You're more impatient than a Dromas waiting for its lunch,"* he'd say. But he isn't awake. And the clock wasn't doing much to help him either with its constant, *annoying* ticking. He had too much energy in his bones despite being utterly exhausted. Should he go for a jog around the city?

'No, not a good idea.' Hyacine would murder him if she found the room empty, and it would be better for Phainon to wake up with someone near him, in case he needs help remembering why he was in the infirmary. Maybe he could strangle him awake and-

On second thought, maybe he *should* open that clinic and talk to himself in front of a mirror everyday away from prying eyes. He heard that self-therapy was the new trend these days.

Mydei groaned again and shifted a little in his chair. His right hand found itself playing with Phainon's hair and he stilled, for a few seconds before he sighed and continued carding his fingers through the locks. He grabbed the book from his lap and flipped through the pages. What surprised him was how invested he slowly became in the story. He wasn't a guy to read romance novels, no matter if they were real or fictional. He's also a person who detests reading poetry, yet he has some in his personal library in Kremnos for his friends. Especially Ptolemy, the sap adored reading those kinds of tales.

…He really does miss those idiots at times. At least they were resting peacefully in the Sea of Souls.

He was halfway through the book- at the part where Mnestia was going to confess their love to the Reason Titan-when Mydei felt something stir beneath his hand. He set the book aside and saw Phainon slowly blink his eyes. The man groaned and shielded his eyes from the sudden light from the window, muttering something under his breath. Mydei drew the curtains and made his way back to his side. He heard a tiny wine escape from Phainon's mouth, and he rolled his eyes, whispering the words *"such a puppy,"* before sitting back down on the chair and massaging his scalp. Phainon let out a hum in approval and turned his head to face him, eyes half-closed. "My..Mydei?" he rasped.

"It's me," Mydei replied. "How do you feel?"

“Hurts…everywhere. Stomach…argh, the *skin* -”

“Don’t scratch the area,” Mydei nearly yelled. “Hyacine took a while to bandage that wound. It’s going to feel itchy for a while, but don’t touch it. Understood?”

Phainon hummed. “What…happened to m-me?”

“What do you remember?”

“We were…fighting the Titan..kin near Aidonia. We had to…split up because th..there were so many of them. Every..thing was a blur after th..at. I was outnumbered, and a Furiae Warrior came at me with…it's massive sword, and I..didn’t have time to react.”

Mydei winced. So that was how he got the wound. “After that?”

“Af-after that you arrived…and then I tri–tried to hide my wound and…tried to distract you, which, *hah*, didn’t…work.”

“Good thing you realized *that*.”

“And then you…noticed and got mad…and ri-ghtfully so. After that, my vision went…hazy. I tried to…listen to your voi..ce, but I was slipping…and fast. Then I felt…something under my back and…”

Phainon’s eyes widened a fraction. He reached for Mydei’s arm and grabbed his wrist. “You…you got me out of there, didn’t you? What I felt were…your arms.”

“Did you expect me to drag you by the foot?” Mydei scoffed. “And for the love of Nikador, next time you’re injured, can you *say something about it?* Hyacine said the healing process wasn’t easy with the amount of blood you lost. Do you…Do you have any idea how much you worried everyone out? You nearly *died* on this very bed. Have you no concern for your life?

Do you know how much you worried me out? was left unsaid.

Phainon looked a little hurt. His gaze drifted to their now intertwined fingers. “I’m sorry,” he whispered. “I didn’t mean to stress everyone out. I thought that…as the Deliverer I…I should be able to shrug the pain off.”

He laughed wetly and rubbed his eyes. “But that doesn’t ma...matter now. He smiled *that* smile again, the one reserved for Mydei and Mydei *only*, though it didn’t quite reach his ears. “You got me here in time. My hero.”

“You got extremely lucky,” said Mydei and sat down on the edge of the bed. He leaned in a little close and sighed softly. “Now, why do you have tears in your eyes, Phainon? There’s no reason to get emotional over this.”

“*Hah!* Says you,” said Phainon, sniffing and rubbing his eyes once more. “I’m not crying because of that. I’d never cry. I'm the Deliverer! I’d- *hmph!*"

The man was rudely cut off by Mydei, who decided to take matters in his own hands and wrapped his arms around the man and carefully pulled him into a hug. He heard Phainon inhale sharply and felt those small tears make their mark on his chiton. “It’s ok,” he said, closing his eyes and rubbing his back. “Today was a lot, wasn’t it? Too much for the two of us. It's ok to feel emotionally drained. We all feel like that once in a while now, don't we? Just rest, Phainon. I’ll be here.”

“Are you sure?” asked Phainon. "Because everyone makes promises, yet very few keep them."

“You really doubt me that much, you dumbass? I’m not one to break my promise now, aren’t I?”

Another laugh, this time a bit louder. “Yeah. Yeah, you never do break them.”

Mydei could text Hyacine later. For now, he continued to hold his friend and let him spill whatever grief he had in him. Once he was better, he swore he was going to make him promise to never hide anything like this ever again. From anyone or from him.

Chapter End Notes

I'm gonna go pass out now-

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> EARLY CHAPTER! I'm still not well but I have gotten better. I feel like the pacing in this one is a lil fast, so heads up! Also, I NEED TO WRITE MORE PHAINON FLUFF AND LESS PHAINON ANGST WHY DO I LIKE TO WRITE HIM SUFFERING 😭😭😭! All I'm saying is, you guys aren't gonna be ready for the last chapter...
>
> Oh, and this is an excuse to write Cyrene. ELYSIA MY BELOVED!!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Marmoreal Market was nearly empty as the Curtain-Fall fell upon Okhema. Shop owners were closing their stores, and parents were calling for their children to come home. The light from the Dawn Device continued to shine, a constant reminder of Kephale's sacrifice. A reminder of why the Flame-Chase must go on.

Mydei strolled through the streets, towards the Janus Device set up near the Forge. Usually, he'd either be sparring with the other Kremnoans from the detachment for a while or at the Chrysos Heir's private baths with a tray of incense and some fruit. But certain… circumstances led to him traversing through the market and onto the roofs, where a certain white-haired swordsman was waiting for him. The crumpled note that started all this was shoved deep into his pocket.

It had been a week since the Titankin incident, and Phainon's recovery was slow, but gradual. The medicines Hyacine prescribed were doing their jobs perfectly. The only issue he had was balancing himself on his feet (He nearly fell twice and would've had a broken nose or, at worst, a concussion if Mydei and Hyacine hadn't caught him in time), but he's been getting better. Yet, he hasn't regained his full range of motion. The moron shouldn't be out of bed, and here he was climbing buildings.

Then again, this was *Phainon* of all people. When has he ever listened to anyone?

The letter stated to meet him at the usual spot and, sure enough, he noticed that snowy white hair after crossing the canopy and jumped down to the balcony. Phainon had his arms crossed and eyes closed. If Mydei didn't know any better, he would've thought the man was sleeping. He snorted under his breath.

"Hm? Already mocking me?" Phainon opened his eyes and tilted his head, smiling *that smile again!* Why does he do that all the time!? "I'm a wounded man, Mydeimos. Have some pity for me."

“You want me to pity the person who’s *not* supposed to be here and instead resting in bed as his physician told him to do? Don’t expect any sympathy from me,” Mydei quipped, ignoring the fuzzy feeling blooming inside him. He moved to stand beside him. “Now spit it out, why did you want me to come here?”

Phainon laughed. “Relax! I just invited you to enjoy the scenery with me. Must you think I always have some ulterior motives whenever I call you for something?”

“Do you *want* me to write down a list?”

“...Ok so maybe sometimes I drag you along for a mission, but cut me some slack! I may be the strongest warrior in all of Okhema, but even I need some help from time to time.”

“The *‘strongest’* you say?” Mydei smirked. “Are you sure about that?”

“Hey! We’ve had many spars where it ended in a tie. If you don’t want me to claim the title, you can’t either.”

Phainon stuck his tongue out, and Mydei rolled his eyes. He lay down on the smooth surface and motioned for Phainon to do the same, which he happily did. Now they found themselves staring up at the clouds, the orange rays piercing through the sky. It wasn’t a ‘sunset’ by any means, but the light at this hour wasn’t so piercing. That was the miracle of the Dawn Device.

“It’s been a long time since I’ve ever seen a sunset.” Mydei voiced out, a bit surprised at his own words. Never has he ever said anything that made him sound so…weak? Vulnerable? Was admitting something so simple such as this meant a sign of weakness?

…No, he was being absurd. Kremnos had the usual day and night cycle before Nikador fell. The last time he truly saw the sunset was the night before his father dropped him into the Sea of Souls. He and his mother were sitting on the balcony. She was running her fingers through his hair while he asked her every question he had. She answered every single one of them with patience and love. Now that Mydei thought about it, her voice that day had sadness in it, and she was weaving her hand through his unruly hair very slowly. It seemed like she knew that his father was going to make that mad decision the next day…

Mydei shook his head. He couldn’t ask anyone the questions he had in his mind. Krateros was an option, but he knew that bringing up the topic of his mother would send him into a fit. He missed her, and so did Mydei. Some topics are too sensitive to bring up.

“I heard from the Kremnoan soldiers I spar with that the sunsets in Kremnos were beautiful. Is it true that the sky would always turn a beautiful shade of pink and orange with hints of purple dotted in various areas?”

“Most of the time, yes. There was a reason for that, but I don’t remember. There are some days when I’d find myself waiting for dusk to come. Of course, it never does.”

“The sun never sets in Okhema,” Phainon said, chuckling under his breath. “The light dims ever so slightly, but it’s never extinguished. I can relate to missing the sunset as well. Back

at…at my home, my friends and I always rushed to the hill that overlooked the village to watch the stars slowly appear in the night sky. The moon follows after, gracing us with her presence and bathing us in her gentle, silvery glow."

Mydei raised his brows. "Aedes Elysiae?" Phainon's home that he never talked about?

"Yeah," Phainon breathed out. "We would trace out the constellations and make up stories. Like the fishes forming a bond with the twins, or the centaur and the bull having a duel. There was no limit."

"No wonder you have weird delusions about so many things."

Phainon barked out a laugh. "Maybe." His gaze lowered, and he met Mydei's eyes. "I wonder, if you and I met when we were kids, do you think we would've been friends? I doubt I'd be able to drag you from the Palace, but from what you've said about your mother, I think she would've let you."

"Honestly…maybe. But even then I'd be busy. Royal responsibilities and all."

"Gah, that's true. Royalty sucks sometimes, doesn't it?"

"It's not as bad as you think it is, Deliverer. And I have a question to ask."

"Shoot."

"This… is the first time you've ever talked about Aedes Elysiae. Why don't you speak more about it?"

At that, Phainon looked a little sad. Like his question brought back some undesirable memories. "Because there's nothing much to talk about. Aedes Elysiae was a small area. Insignificant in the eyes of history. You can't compare it with the likes of Castrum Kremnos or Okhema, or even Aidonia. Everyone knows about Kremnos, and you're its Crowned Prince, of course, it makes sense for you to talk highly about your home. I'm just someone from a village no one will know about. "

"...That doesn't matter." *'That should* ***never*** *matter,'* Mydei thought. Even if Castrum Kremnos wasn't the famed city it is with a long-lasting dynasty, he'd still talk about it with pride if given the chance. And he knows Phainon loves Aedes Elysiae with all his heart. His home shaped him, *moulded him* into the Hero he is today. "What matters are the memories that you made with your friends. Your family. Aedes Elysiae may not be famous, but it was still a place where people called home. The place that *you* called home."

"I-"

"So don't feel embarrassed and feel proud that you, Phainon, the Deliverer, and a Chrysos Heir on the path of the Flame-Chase are from a simple yet humble background with parents who would have loved you with all their being. No one will ever judge you. Heck, I *definitely* won't, and I know you know that very well."

"Mydei-"

“And I’m…actually kind of curious about your home. I only know about the great Deliverer, yet you know me *and* Castrum Kremnos. Isn’t that a little unfair?”

“You…are? I mean, you *want* to know?” Phainon asked. His voice was low, doubtful. Mydei could only wonder what thoughts were plaguing his mind. One of these days he’ll understand. For now, he wants the man to speak freely without any hesitation.

“Yes,” Mydei says firmly. He grabs Phainon’s hand and gently squeezes it. “I’m not lying when I earlier said that I’m genuinely curious about Aedes Elysiae. It sounds like you have a bunch of fond memories of the place.”

Phainon chuckled. “That I do. In that case… hmm…where do I even start?”

“Why not talk about your friends?”

“My friends, huh? Well, that certainly is a start.” Phainon took in a deep breath and exhaled slowly. His eyes were now looking up at the clouds. “I had a bunch of friends growing up. Despite my home being small, we were quite populated. Everyone got along with each other well and the kids always played in the grass or up the hill that overlooked the village. Sometimes we play hide-and-seek in the cornfields while the farmers watch us and laugh. They never minded as long as we didn’t damage any of the plants. Sometimes we like to weave flower crowns and play with wooden swords. I always manage to ‘stab’ everyone when I’m the king for the day, and they all complained it was because I had longer legs, so I ran faster than them.”

“No wonder you use a greatsword,” said Mydei, smirking. “You were training with one even before you were an adolescent.”

“I was inspired by the fairytales my mother read to me at night.” Phainon shrugged. He shot a mischievous smile at him. “Now that I remember, we *did* have a small library that housed almost every fairytale ever written in Amphoreus, plus a few extra. It certainly wasn’t that impressive, but to us, every time we took a step inside, it felt like we were entering the Dream Land. I’m not sure if you’d like it though.”

“If there are books, that’s good enough for me.”

“I- *really?* So you…You know what, I’ll interrogate you about that later. Where was I again? Oh, *yes* ! Toy swords!”

Mydei snickered at the way Phainon’s hands moved as he continued to ramble on about the different games he played with his companions. He found it…endearing. He could *see* the tension slowly dissipating from him, replaced with pure, unadulterated happiness. He noticed how his eyes crinkled in the corners when talking about the games he played, his excited laughs when explaining what he called the ‘best parts’ made his heart warm up a little. Phainon was a happy and outgoing person in general, but this was the first time Mydei had seen him *glowing.*

Hopefully, once everything is said and done and the Flame-Chase is over, Phainon would no longer need to hide behind a mask.

“Out of all my friends,” Phainon said, and Mydei felt him squeeze his hand again, “there was one who stood out the most.” His voice was low, mourning. “She and I met under some… very unique circumstances, but she was the first friend I ever made. I…think you would’ve liked her. I can see you and her getting along splendidly.”

“What was her name?”

“Cyrene.”

‘Cyrene.’ “That’s a lovely name,” said Mydei.

“She was a lovely person,” said Phainon. “We’d go chase the fairies in the afternoon after we’d finish eating our lunch. Sometimes we’d have a picnic under the singular tree on the hill. She’d always make me flower crowns and bracelets and tell me all sorts of stories she heard from other people. She was someone who was shrouded in mystery, but she was the kindest person I ever met- and that’s saying a lot, considering everyone in the village were really nice people. Oh, and growing up I used to have terrible nightmares. Like, *terrible* ones where I’d wake up screaming my lungs out. My parents tried everything they could to get them to stop, but nothing worked. I told Cyrene about it, and she volunteered to stop by my house every night at around 10:00 to sing me a lullaby. At first, I doubted it’d work. My mother tried to do just that, and it did put me to sleep just fine, but an hour later I was wide awake with sweat covering my forehead. Yet, I let her try and, to my absolute shock and surprise, I woke up the next morning completely well rested with not even a single nightmare. I told her excitedly that it worked, and she laughed and elbowed me in the ribs, telling me it’d work. We had a long laugh before she started making another flower crown.”

Mydei hummed, picturing a young Phainon playing in the grass with a wide smile, being chased by a girl with lemonade-pink hair, giggling loudly and making flower crowns under a tree. Having a friend like that…he knows someone like her is having a built-in support system that someone could always rely on. And from what he’s said, Phainon and Cyrene were each other’s support system. He had friends that he always hung out with in the library or the training grounds, but he never got to experience the thrill of childhood. It was always him and his mother.

He squeezed Phainon’s hand to get his attention. “You know, if she were still…I’d love to meet her.”

Phainon’s eyes were watering a little again, but that soft smile stayed. "Heh, just like I said."

"Just like you said."

Phainon let go of his hand and shifted closer, resting his head on Mydei's arm with a contented sigh, showing no remorse for his attempt to cut off his blood circulation. If he had done this in the beginning when they met, Mydei would've just shoved him off. The little weasel thinks he has him wrapped up in his little metaphorical finger?

...His hands were stroking his scalp. Tenderly too, if he may add. Welp, it is indeed the end of the universe. The proud Prince of Castrum Kremnos was now a sappy idiot.

But, with Phainon, he'll let himself loosen up a little. At least there was no one watching them.

Chapter End Notes

Shameless self promotion ik but if you wanna follow me on insta feel free to do so here:

I think Cyrene and Mydei would've been BFF's had they met and gang up on poor Phainon lol. What are your thoughts?

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

> This is short chapter but I'm releasing this chapter a little earlier because I think the last chapter (we're already on the last chapter?? Help me) is gonna be a tiny bit longer than the others, and I'm gonna take some time to write it. I have a wedding to attend to and places to go it's crazy 😭😭. Like I said before, I don't think you guys are ready to read the last chapter...heck, I don't think *I'm* ready to type the last chapter out 😭😭😭.
>
> Also I may have accidentally described a certain something...after you're done reading you'll know what I mean (shld I make my own AU of sorts?) I have another fic planned but lets see.
>
> And yes Phainon doesn't exactly show up but he DOES smile thru paper lmfao.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The art of gift-giving. If it could be called an art.

There's no specific occasion where one needs to give something to their loved ones. In fact, it happens almost all the time in the Holy City. Of course, there was Mnestia's Day, where almost all the gift shops would be crowded with spouses picking out the perfect last-minute gifts for their lovers or family members. Love wasn't restricted to only romance after all.

But this particular gift that Mydei had in mind was one he commissioned about a week ago to Chartonus, and today just so happened to be the day he had to go to collect it.

Phainon was not currently in Okhema, having been deployed to Janusopolis to help some of the priests fend off the abominations of the Black Tide while they perform some prayer. He wasn't sure of the details, but Lady Tribbie was with him to smoothen out any possible complications. Their numbers weren't huge, so Aglaea sent only him to deal with it.

"It shouldn't take long," he had said when they were at the bakery trying out the new pastries the day before the mission. He gently bumped his shoulder. "I'll be in and out of there before you know it, and then we'll return to our daily sparring session."

"Try not to get injured and then *we'll see," Mydei scoffed, flicking his forehead. Phainon let out an indignant yelp and kicked his shin. "Kephale knows what you'll do to yourself this time, just like last time where-"*

"Ok, do we need to talk about last time?" said Phainon, glaring at him. "I said I would never repeat that. Have some faith in me, Mydei!"

"If only," Mydei muttered under his breath. Phainon huffed.

“But I will be fine. Besides, I’ll be with Lady Tribbie. If anything happens to me, I swear I’ll tell her. It’s not like I cannot *hide any wounds from her…”*

That…was true. The triplets may look like children, but everyone knows they are the wisest individuals among both the people of Amphoreus and the Chrysos Heirs. Oh, and nothing escapes their sights. Especially when it comes to Lady Tribbie. Perhaps that’s the reason why Aglaea wanted her to tag along. Well, good on her part. The Deliverer needed a babysitter.

Mydei took a bite out of his honey cake and cleared his throat. “If anything happens and you hide it from me, I will ask Lady Tribbie for all the details. Do you understand me?”

“Aye aye, captain!” Phainon exclaimed, throwing him a mock salute. Mydei rolled his eyes and shoved a piece of cake in the other’s mouth to shut him up, and smirked when he started to cough and wheeze. He slid his cup of water over the table and roared with laughter when Phainon all but yoinked the chalice and gulped everything down in one go. Oh, how he wished he had his teleslate with him.

It didn't take him long to reach Chartonus’ shop, where he found the Mountain-Dweller hammering away on the forge. There were no signs of his assistants, which struck him as odd, but he figured they might be doing something else. He waved to the blacksmith when he managed to catch his eye. “Chartonus!”

“Prince Mydeimos,” said Chartonus, setting aside his hammer to grab something from his table. “Came on time, you did. Your order finished, I did yesterday.”

“Thank you. Where are Tum and Siskel?”

“A task, I sent them to do. Before Action Hour tomorrow, they will arrive. Inspect your weapon, for now.”

Chartonus set the sword and bow down on the bench for Mydei to inspect. He carefully picked the blade up and looked at it from all angles. The designs were a bit complicated, which was why Mydei had commissioned him one week in advance with a drawing of how he wanted it to look.

Now, he knows Phainon’s greatsword was virtually unbreakable, having been forged by Chartonus himself, but it’s always good to have a wide array of weaponry in one's arsenal. As for the bow, well, Phainon has been getting quite better at his aim recently, and Mydei was beyond impressed when he shot three arrows at once right and landed them all at the center of the target. He knew he was ready to try using a better-built bow. More specifically, a recurve bow.

Mydei wanted them to look the same but also a little different. The body of the bow was primarily silver with blue accents and three blue feathers on both the upper and lower tips. Little half sun motifs were on each tiller with a sturdy grip right in the middle. He tested the string on the bow, humming in satisfaction at the smooth draw. It wasn’t too tight either. The sword, on the other hand, was what he was the most excited about.

While the bow was a bright silver glimmering in the night, the sword was obsidian black with a crescent moon at the hilt with a circular frame. The blade was long and sharp, slightly bent at the top to help kill enemies faster. He gently bent the sword's tip and performed a few slow swings. Everything looked perfect.

"Thank you, Chartonus," Mydei said with a small smile, giving the weapons back to the blacksmith so he could wrap them up. "They look and feel wonderful, especially considering I only gave you one week. I should have said this before, but my apologies for asking you to make these on such short notice."

"No need to apologize, there is," said Chartonus, waving him off with his hand. "Create anything you want in one week, I can. Always honored to craft weapons for the Chrysos Heirs, I am."

Of course he was. Chartonus has always been proud to aid in the Flame Chase journey in his own way. Sometimes he'd stop to wonder just what his ancestors were thinking when they decided to enslave the Mountain-Dwellers. Mydei had great respect for Chartonus for breaking the shackles of his people and setting them free. He wasn't privy to all the details, but he struck a deal with one of the Kremnoan High Elders that he'd do…something in exchange for his people's freedom.

Quite frankly, he didn't want to know.

After paying for the weapons (he unceremoniously dropped the coin sack before speed walking out of there lest Chartonus finds out he paid double the intended amount and chase after him), he made his way to the Heir's private quarters. He knows for a fact that Phainon rarely ever keeps his room locked because the man admitted it to him on a random day. His reason was that they never had locks to their doors and no one ever stole from them. Regardless, Mydei still gently scolded him and told him to always be wary of his surroundings even outside the battlefield. They both know some people wanted to eliminate them. The Council of Elders certainly wanted to recall the power they gave to the Heir's as soon as possible and eliminate them.

…To his credit, the Deliverer *was* trying his best to change his habits, but there were some days when he'd forget and leave his room completely forgetting to slide the lock into place. Like today. However, just this once, Mydei was happy he did.

He opened the door and went straight to his drawer, setting the package on his bed along the way. Mydei grabbed a piece of parchment, one of Phainon's quills, a bottle of ink, and started to write out a letter.

> *Deliverer*
>
> *I'm not sure when you'll be back, but something tells me you'll be here tomorrow. I won't be up to greet you and Lady Tribbie, so I'm leaving these here for you. Inside the package, you'll find two weapons handcrafted by Chartonus himself, so don't worry about their quality.*

You've gotten better with handling a bow recently, so I thought it was about time you had a proper one. As for the sword, you can't always rely on that one greatsword of yours. Better have some backup weapons in case you lose your greatsword to your carelessness, which I can see happening.

Anyways, we'll test them out when we spar the next day. There's no need to thank me for this, so it will be unnecessary to send me a text back. I do hope you enjoy these little offerings.

-Mydei

Mydei screwed the ink bottle shut, placed both it and the quill back in their proper places and kept the letter on top of the package. Then, without looking back, he headed for his own room, but not before locking the door from the outside. Of course, that isn't going to do much, but don't they say it's the thought that counts?

The rays from the Dawn Device crept through the curtains as the Entry Hour greeted the Holy City. The streets are slowly filling with residents as they set up their shops and restock their wares.

Mydei sat up on his bed and rubbed his eyes, blinking away the last vestiges of sleep that clung to him. Today was going to be a long day-training some of the youngsters from the Kremnoan Detachment, helping advertise the new honey cakes the bakery made, as well as getting some free samples once it's over), supervise a race for the kids (because why not?) and train a bit by himself. He couldn't remember the last time his schedule was this packed.

He stretched his arms for a bit and, without looking, grabbed his teleslate when his fingers brushed against something smooth and slightly waxy. He looked up to find, lo and behold, a rolled-up piece of parchment sitting next to his teleslate, held together by a white string. He didn't have to think long to know who had placed it there.

Of *course,* Phainon would want to thank him somehow, despite telling him it wasn't needed. But then again…

'...Cute.'

Since he made such an effort to write a thank you, Mydei couldn't just throw it away without reading first. Feeling a smirk tugging at his lips, he untied the string and let the parchment unfurl.

Mydei

First off, you know I'd write a letter back to you to say thanks-I mean, I could've just said thank you in person, but we all know how busy the Crown Prince is these days. Second, you can't exactly be mad at me for writing a letter back when you clearly mentioned I shouldn't ***text*** *you.*

As for the gifts, I feel honored. When did you have the time to go behind my back and commission all these? I think I need to interrogate Chartonus to know your secrets! But alas, I decided against it. The bow feels pretty light, and its draw power is super strong. It feels ten times better than the training one. And as for the sword, well, you've finally given me the key to finishing my Dark Swordsmaster get-up. Hahaha, nothing is stopping me now! Not even Aglaea! Now the whole world will soon know about their shining hero in black!

I know you're busy the whole morning and afternoon, so let's have a spar at around 6:00. That is, if you think you can still stand on your own two feet by then. Kephale knows you need strength. But anyway, I will see you later!

-Phainon

"...HKS," Mydei muttered, rolling his eyes. A fond smile replaced the smirk on his face. He could imagine that dork's smile as he wrote the letter, the smile that made him weak most of the time. He chuckled and kept the letter on the table and his way to his closet to start getting ready for the day. But, as he was choosing what to wear for the day, a thought occurred to him…

Wait a second…

How did Phainon manage to break into his room and place the letter on his bedside table? And then he realized he forgot to read the note at the bottom of the letter.

Mydei ran back to the table and unscrolled the parchment.

P:S: You left your room unlocked. Starting to develop my bad habits I see.

He slammed his head on the wall.

Chapter End Notes

I might be writing some extra scenes since some of you guys requested it, and I have two in mind, do you guys have some you want me to write?

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> WE'RE HERE AT THE END!!!!!! Aaaaaahhh I'm so sorry it took so long, this chapter was making me cry 😭😭😭. Thank you for all the kudos and comments (I love love LOVE reading what you guys have to say!) I really hope you love this final chapter, even if it's a bit dialogue-heavy!
>
> As for the extra chapters, I'll be writing those later, but I do have some ideas for those! I have an idea for another fic, but what do you guys wanna see? Perhaps another 5+1 fic but from Phainon's POV? Please do let me know!
>
> (And for the ending...I thought of it in the last minute eheheheh) But anyway, onto the more important question: HOW DID YOUR CASTORICE PULLS GO? I got that gal in 82 pulls (I was guaranteed so there was a lot of PAIN!) and her lc in a 10 pull (at 2 pity.) I do hope all of you get her if you plan to pull for her!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The wind was gentle, stirring up small flecks of dirt from the ground. Specks of something black were scattered in various places, which Mydei instantly recognized as ashes. It’s so ironic that the place reeked of death, yet the grass continued to grow, leeching off the remains of the dead.

From where they were standing, Mydei could see everything, and nothing. If he closed his eyes, he could envision how the village looked at its prime. The rice and cornfields swaying in the breeze, the loud laughter of the children, the hustle and bustle of the people. He could only wonder what Phainon must be thinking at the moment.

Never in a million years did Mydei imagine he would find himself standing on the hill Phainon had told him countless stories about. The hill he and his friends laid on to watch the stars, where they had picnics. The hill that overlooked his home.

Aedes Elysiae.

Or whatever was left of it.

He remembered Phainon’s words- the crimson moon that hung over the sky as the Black Tide swept everything away. That black-robed swordmaster who slayed Cyrene, the cries of the people. As the Demi-God of Strife, he had now gained a new understanding—not only of war and bloodlust in battle but also of its aftermath: the fear, the loss, and the pain. Divinity wiped away Aglaea’s emotions, but for Mydei, it only heightened them.

Mydei closed his eyes again and sighed in relief when he couldn't sense any monsters. The last thing they needed was Titankin to ruin the moment. He didn't want to stain any part of the land with his blood crystals. Beside him, Phainon looked…uneasy, for the most part. There was an unreadable expression on his face. If he remembered correctly, it's the Deliverer's first time returning home since the incident.

"Phainon?" Mydei said, concern seeping into his voice. He hadn't spoken a word during their trip, which unsettled him. At first, it made sense—anyone would fall silent when returning to the ruins of the place they once called home. But this felt different, too different. He'd expected him to comment here and there, but not even a single peep came out of his mouth. Another ability he acquired after claiming the Core Flame was sensing the emotions seeping from others. It allowed him to detect his enemies from afar and gave him time to prepare his attack. Right now, it was making him a bit uneasy.

As he expected, he got no response. "Phainon," Mydei tried again, bumping his shoulder into his. Phainon let out a tiny gasp and snapped his head up, muscles all tensed. He raised a brow and crossed his arms. "Are you ok?"

"Never better!" he exclaimed, putting on what Mydei immediately identified as a 'phony grin,' and Mydei narrowed his eyes. Phainon chuckled nervously under his scrutinizing glare and rubbed the back of his neck, that grin instantly melting off his face. "Ok, yeah, I'm not feeling well. In fact, I think I feel sick."

That wasn't surprising. It wasn't only the stench of death that made them nauseous. The whole place looked like a warzone.

"This isn't how I wanted you to see my home," he heard Phainon say. His head hung low again, his bangs covering his face. "I thought…I was under the impression something must have survived here. A house, or maybe a door. But from here…I don't see anything."

"You never saw the village after the incident?"

"I turned around and never looked back. Like a coward." Phainon hissed.

"Stop it," Mydei said, smacking his shoulder. "Even if you had, there's nothing you could have done. You were young and powerless. You were just a child."

"If only I hadn't been one," that familiar, broken whisper escaped him. A tone Phainon rarely used—but when he did, it was to tear himself down. To blame himself for things beyond his control, yet things he believed would have ended differently if only he had been stronger. It hurt everyone to see him get emotional over this. His thoughts, his dreams, his nightmares all stem from one place and one place alone.

And…in some ways, he could relate to the feeling. His mother sacrificed herself so that he could keep living. Thanks to Caelus' time–travelling abilities and the power to access memory fragments, he found out his accursed *father* had been poisoning her daily, leading up to that ill–fated battle. The rage he felt that day was so strong, he almost demanded Caelus that he'd be sent back in time just so he could kill that wretched, pathetic excuse of a human being all over again. His blood crystals were growing out of his body in response to the

overwhelming fury, and it was only after Caelus shook him hard by the shoulders and yelled at him to snap out of it that he finally managed to calm down, though the crystals took a while to disappear.

Case in point, they both had regrets. Many regrets, but there wasn't anything they could do about it now. All they could do is keep pushing forward towards that promised new tomorrow. That was the only way the dead could truly be avenged. They both knew that. Today was the day Phainon was going to face his past after so many years.

"Are you ready to go down there?"

"I…"

"Or we could wait a few minutes until you've pulled yourself together."

"No," Phainon said with such conviction it made Mydei hesitate a little. But before he could say anything, the Deliverer continued to speak. "If I keep second-guessing myself I'll never go down there and face my fears. I'm ready, Mydei. I am."

Mydei sighed and shook his head, a small smile adorning his face. Oh, that Deliverer. He'd never change, and that was probably for the better. "In that case, lead the way."

"Of course, my Prince. Just try to keep up."

"The demigod of Strife doesn't need someone to tell him to 'keep up.'"

"Sure sure. Next time I see you trudging far behind me, I'll assume it's for dramatic effects. The blood crystals add a nice touch too."

Phainon cackled as Mydei hurled a string of Kremnoan curses at him.

Mydei felt like someone was twisting a knife into his gut as he walked through the fields. Phainon was ahead of him, walking at a much slower pace, no doubt taking it all in. Ashes were in the air, on the ground, and he couldn't tell which of them were from wood and which were from the…from the long gone corpses.

He could feel the lingering touch of Thanatos weighing heavily on his back. His now sharp and clear eyesight could make out faint bloodstains that had not faded with time. When Castrum Kremnos fell, there was at least something in the city he could salvage from the ruins for the other soldiers. Nothing here survived. Not even a single piece of plank.

Phainon twirled around, the sun casting a warm glow on his hair, beckoning him to come stand next to him. "This, if memory serves me right, is where my house used to be."

Mydei could make out the outline of where the house stood. A bit big, probably bigger than most of the other houses here. If Caelus and Mem had tagged along, they could have used Oronyx's blessing to see the village before it was destroyed, but he doubted that was something Phainon would want to see now. He mentioned the houses were built using tar and

bricks, and the doors from a large oak tree. As expected, there wasn't anything here, not even bones.

The Flame Reaver made sure nothing was left behind.

"I remember the story of how the house was built," Phainon said, and his voice was starting to crack a little. He brushed his hand against his, and he grabbed it with no hesitation. "My mother and father met at this very spot under the moon when they were teenagers. I wouldn't call it love at first sight, but from what my mom told me, it might as well have been. Dad made her a flower crown and she got all flustered. She said, *"What kind of man walks up to a random woman he's never met, gives her a flower crown, and acts all flirtatious with her?"* in the most comical, exaggerated voice ever."

Mydei snorted. That explained why Phainon was a romantic at heart. "I'm assuming it worked then."

"It worked well. More than well. Soon after, they found themselves meeting here often with little gifts in hand. They weren't anything grand by all means, but they meant the world to them. Then, one day, my dad brought a brick and a box. It turned out that he was preparing to propose to her and lay down that brick as a sort of foundation to start their new relationship. My mom said yes, and the rest is history. They happily got married at the center of the village under a beautiful flower arch. She said it was the most beautiful day of her life—along with the day I was born."

"So, the magnificent Deliverer really *did* come into this world screaming his tiny head off."

"Pfft, *Mydei!*" Phainon exclaimed, shoving the prince while said prince howled in laughter. "*All* babies come into the world screaming. Also, my head is not tiny! *Also*, what a way to ruin the damp mood, Mr. Demi-God of Strife."

"You laughed too," Mydei snorted, rapping him on the top of his head. He snickered when he heard the man yelp. "If I hadn't said anything sooner you'd be brooding right about now, and it'd be harder for me to snap you out of it." It was the truth. He honestly loved that Phainon was telling him more stories of his childhood, but right now he looked like he needed an emotional break. Besides, teasing him now and then was his forte. He was glad divinity hadn't stripped him of that.

Phainon pouted, puffing up his cheek. He placed one hand on his hip and pointed an accusatory finger at him. "I don't *brood,* Mydeimos. Brooding is not my thing. I don't know how to brood. *You,* on the other hand, brooded all the time when you were in Okhema. So much so, I have to drag you from all your hiding spots all the time to get you to spar with me, and *that* somehow always works!"

"Because it just so happened that a spar was exactly what I needed to cheer myself up all the time. Have you considered that as a possibility?" Mydei shot back, smirking.

"Right. *A spar was exactly what you needed to cheer yourself up all the time.* Sure thing, Mydei, sure."

Phainon faced the ruins, and his next words came out softer. “Thanks for the small distraction. I really appreciate it but…I kind of need to be alone right now here.” He let out a bitter laugh. “I-I know I may sound rude and everything but I *need* thi-”

“Shut up-again,” Mydei cut him off, squeezing his shoulder. “Why are you apologizing? I get it, and I’m certainly not offended. If you need some space, just say so. I’ll be here if you need me, ok?”

“Thank you,” Phainon muttered. With that, Mydei stepped away and decided to explore a little. He made sure to maintain his distance but to stay as close as he could in case Phainon called him. The idiot. One of these days, he’ll come visit Okhema just to beat some sense into the man.

The sun was hanging below the sky, and the wind was starting to pick up. Mydei brushed his bangs from his face and knelt. Hovering his hand over the ash-covered ground, he closed his eyes, reaching out to the land as it once was, searching for anything that remained. Back in Castrum Kremnos, he saw the city as it had been at its peak—soldiers lined up on the stairs, and people from the past celebrating their king’s long-awaited return. It was sort of similar to Caelus’ ability, but he couldn’t access memory fragments or bring the past to life. However, he does use it sometimes to replay some moments, gaining information as to what went on during his time in the Sea of Souls and leading up to his father's death.

He became something of a history nerd after that. Looking at the past gave him more information than he could ever dream of. None of what he saw would be in the books in his library, or any other library for that matter. It was as his mother said-only the strong will note what happened. Only the ones with power would. The truth may never be fully uncovered unless someone actually tries to look for it. Now, speaking of the library…

Mydei jogged down a stone path and found what he was looking for-the remains of a leather book. The very *tattered* remains of a leather book.

So this was where the library stood. It wasn’t huge by any means, but it appeared it was big enough to house all the books the people here would ever need.

He ran his fingers against the material, letting the story speak for itself. It was a diary that belonged to a young girl. A thick one that had many pages and held many tales. He couldn’t make out the full details of how the girl looked, though he managed to catch a few glimpses-cerulean eyes with pink dots scattered around the iris, shoulder-length lemon-pink hair framing her face with a small white clip pinned on the right. A dark purple and white dress with long sleeves…why did this sound familiar to him?”

Mydei stood up and continued to walk down the faded path, his heart pounding in his chest. The leaves from the trees fell from the branches, some landing on his hair and body. A mixture of gold and green, crunching under his foot. He tried to recall where he had seen someone like that. *Has* he seen someone like that before?

So far, he found nothing of value. He had hoped to find something to salvage here, but considering the intensity of the fire, coupled with the Black Tide, finding anything intact would be nothing short of a miracle. Mydei’s eyes scanned the area, hoping to find something

that might help him uncover more memories. Maybe then, he'll know what happened to the village in the aftermath of the fire and tell Phainon. Maybe some survivors managed to escape in time and are taking refuge somewhere. If that's the case, they could bring them back to Okhema. That is, *if* there were any, and from what Phainon told him, his hopes were low.

So far, nothing. He wondered what the Deliverer was doing right about now. It was about time he checked on her.

As he was about to turn away and check somewhere else and Phainon, a sudden gleam of white caught his attention from the corner of his eye. Squinting, he broke into a jog toward the bushes where the light was coming from and brushed them aside.

Right there, caught on one of the twigs, he found the source. It looked to be an exquisite hairpin. It had a golden diamond with small scorch marks and two torn petals on either side. It was a simple thing, yet also really beautiful.

Holding his breath, Mydei carefully extracted the pin from the bush and made sure his talons didn't accidentally damage the accessory any further. It stayed intact in his hands, and he let out a breath he hadn't realized he was holding. He found something. He *actually found something* .

Making his way back to the place where the library was, he closed his eyes. Mydei couldn't make out anything at first-all there was only darkness, until he heard laughter. A girl's laughter echoed around him. She sounded young, maybe around fifteen or sixteen years old. Then he saw flashes of pink hair, followed by a purple and white dress with gold accents. Once again, deja vu hit him like a Dromas charging at him at full speed, and he couldn't figure out for the life of him why.

Whatever. He'll figure it out later. For now, he should go show Phainon what he found.

And so he tucked the clip into his little pouch and made his way back up the little slope where Phainon was standing. His cape was flitting in the wind, his posture rigid. He saw the man opening and clenching his fists. He looked like he was about to burst a vein. Typical Deliverer, needing someone to bring him back to solid ground.

Mydei shoved him.

Phainon screamed.

He laughed hard.

Phainon scowled at him. "What was that for!?"

"Nothing," Mydei replied, wheezing. He straightened up and coughed. "But in all seriousness, it's ok to mourn, but if I hadn't done that, you'd be trapped somewhere in your pretty little brain and never come back. Remember to not lose yourself."

He sighed and walked into Mydei's open arms. "I know," he sighed, hugging him back. "I guess I'm glad to have you here."

"You should be."

"But why are you here? Weren't you looking for things to read?"

"First of all, it's not called *reading,* Deliverer. And second, I'm here because…I found something I need to show you."

"WHAT?" Phainon looked up, eyes blown wide. His grip around Mydei tightened. "Mydei, what are you talking about? You mean to say you…actually found something?"

Mydei nodded. "I know it sounds absurd, but I have the object in my pouch. It's a little scorched, but otherwise intact."

Phainon's breathing hitched. His hands trembled as he pulled away from the prince. Staggering back on shaky legs, he rasped, "I don't believe it." Even his voice sounded raw. Mydei took a step forward, his gauntleted hand reaching out, but Phainon only backed away further. "I-I *can't* for some reason. That fire didn't leave behind even a single straw of hay. And yet you found something whole?"

And all of a sudden he started to laugh hysterically, throwing one arm across his face. "I can't believe this. I just can't *believe it!* Whatever you found back there, it can't be real. Check your pouch again. It must be dust by now."

Mydei gritted his teeth, unsure of what to say. Phainon's laughter ceased, and his gaze was now elsewhere, biting his lower lip. In the dying light, he could see the tears gathering in his eyes. It was… weird seeing him so beaten down. And depressing. He looked so…so *young* and helpless right now, it pained him.

He reached into his pouch and grabbed the clip, smiling to himself– it was still intact. However, the weird sense of deja vu hit him hard once again upon laying his fingers on it. It was as if his body-his senses to be more specific, were screaming at him that they knew who the owner of the clip was.

"Phainon," he called out. "Come here. I think you'll be surprised that my little finding has, in fact, *not* turned into dust as you had put it."

Phainon hesitated, eyes flickering at him and where he was standing. He looked torn between coming closer or staying put, like a frightened animal. No matter.

He'll just go up to him and show him. No words, no grand gestures-just walk up and show him that what was in his hand was real.

So, he did just that. He stood right in front of Phainon, gently placed two fingers under his chin, and lifted his head. Then he let go and held up the pin. From this angle, the gold of the clip caught the light perfectly, casting it in an elegant, radiant glow. Mydei had to admit whoever made it had some remarkable skill.

However, instead of smiling or feeling happy, Phainon's eyes widened in fear and something else, his body stiffening like he had just seen a ghost. His body started to tremble violently again, and he backed away. Mydei tilted his head in confusion, lowering his hand. That… wasn't what he was expecting. Shock, yes. Bewilderment? Obviously. But fear?

"Phainon?"

"Where did you get that?" Phainon asked, his voice cracking. His gaze stayed locked on the pin resting in Mydei's hand. Slowly, he curled in on himself, as if trying to disappear. Mydei's confusion deepened — this wasn't the reaction he had expected at all.

He took a step forward. "Phainon? What's going-"

"Answer the damn question, Mydei!" Phainon yelled. He was getting more frazzled by the second. "Where the fuck did you find that? The *exact spot!* "

"On the branch of a bush!" he answered quickly. "Like I said before, it was near the library. What's going on, Phainon? Talk to me!"

But Phainon never did. Instead, he stumbled back, slapping a hand over his mouth as he screamed a string of desperate no's. Tears streamed down his face as sobs began to rack his body. Mydei screamed his name, but he didn't respond. A wave of fear crashed over him.

What was going on? What was happening? Was there something he was missing? Was there…

Wait.

His visions…that *girl*–

Oh.

It hit him. Judging by Phainon's reaction, the clip wasn't just important — it was *significant* . But it wasn't about the clip itself. It was about the one who owned it. A girl with lemon-pink hair and bright blue eyes. A girl who used to run through the fields in a white and purple dress. A girl Phainon cherished more than anything, deep in his heart.

Oh.

Oh *Titans.*

Did he just make a mistake?

Phainon had thought when he and Mydei first arrived at the ruins of Aedes Elysiae that there would be nothing left to find. After all, the massive fire had burned everything to ash. Not even the skeletal remains of the people had survived. The Flame Reaver had made sure there were no survivors- and that nothing remained.

And yet, Mydei was here, holding Cyrene's hairpin. *Cyrene's hairpin.* He remembered watching that wretched, vile swordmaster cut her down right in front of his eyes. He saw the light leave her eyes. She died in his arms with a small smile on her face. He gripped her hand tightly, afraid to let her go. *He couldn't let her go.* Tears had started to fall uncontrollably from his eyes, and his throat *hurt* with all the screaming he had done. What almost made him laugh was that Cyrene was trying to comfort him. Comfort him! Whilst she was dying! Phainon was so close to telling her to shut up and conserve her energy.

He knew saying that was hopeless, but he did anyway. And when she faded to dust, everything was gone. No trace of Cyrene remained. Nothing was there. So how does that explain the pin in his hand?

"No. No no no no no no ***no*** *!* " Phainon said, covering his mouth, choking back tears. It couldn't be. *It couldn't be.* This has got to be some nasty prank, right? Mydei was pulling a prank on him to make him laugh! That's got to be it, yes!

But…Mydei wasn't that kind of person. He understands Phainon more than anyone else. He knew what pain and loss felt like, and he wouldn't wish that on anyone. The sadness on his face only confirmed it—this was real. At that moment, he found himself wondering if Cyrene had worn her hair clip when she died. And even then, the fire and the Black Tide left nothing intact.

He forced his mouth to work, but all that came out were broken words. "Please tell me my eyes aren't working, Mydei. Please tell me that isn't real. It *can't* be."

Through his blurry vision, he saw Mydei approaching slowly, one hand gently outstretched. He said something, but Phainon didn't hear him. His heart thundered, and it felt as if a hand had wrapped around his lungs, tightening with every breath he took. His entire body was shaking as memories-those *damn* memories that he shoved into the dark recesses of his mind were now flooding his mind, drowning him. *'Oh Titans, I think I'm actually going to die.'*

He furiously rubbed his eyes in an attempt to clear his vision to no avail. His heart and body started to hurt terribly. Despite all his efforts a tiny sob tore escaped his mouth. Then another one. Then another, until they started to rattle his whole body and he started to hyperventilate. He heard Mydei yell out his name. He wanted to respond, but every nerve in his body was on fire.

Whatever strength he had left his body, and Phainon collapsed to his knees. Pain flared through them, but he hardly noticed. Instead, he clutched himself and sobbed, yelling Cyrene's name like it might bring her back, every breath wracked with grief. And it was all because of one small hair clip—a simple thing, yet it carried a story all its own.

"Cyrene!" Phainon yelled, waving his arms. "There you are!"

"Hm? Where else would I be silly?" said Cyrene in a playful tone, flicking his forehead. He jumped back and groaned, rubbing the area gently.

"Well, I thought you would be at your home at this time, but you weren't there. And I couldn't find you anywhere in the village."

“And so you came to the one spot you knew I’d be in.”

“You say I’m easy to read, but you are too, Cyrene.”

“Has anyone ever told you that you’re so cute?” Cyrene said, reaching over to pinch Phainon’s cheeks. He dodged them effortlessly and moved to sit down on the other side, glaring at her. She laughed. “Fine, I’ll let your cheeks survive for one day.”

Phainon huffed and muttered, “Why not on all the days?” Cyrene merely rolled her eyes. “Anyways, stop distracting me! Let me talk now!”

“Alright, alright. So then, why has our heroic Deliverer sought out this pretty damsel today?”

“No reason, I just wanted to give you something,” Phainon said, fishing something out of his back pocket. He didn’t miss the way her eyes twinkled in surprise. “I had some help from my mother, but I wanted to make something as a thank you present for being my friend. ”

Silly little goose, why are you thanking me for being your friend?” Cyrene laughed, reaching out to ruffle his hair, earning a squawk from Phainon. “No matter what, we’ll always be friends. You really didn’t have to make anything for me.”

“First of all, shut up,” Phainon said, putting a finger on her lips. He narrowed his eyes. “I wanted to make something for you, so you have no choice but to accept. Now, close your eyes and give me your hand. And do not open them unless I tell you to.”

“Oh? Should I be worried?” Cyrene teased, arching a brow but closing her eyes anyway, a mischievous smile tugging at her lips. Phainon groaned once again and muttered, “You are way too dramatic for your own good.” He grabbed her hand and placed his gift on her palm, and closed it. He then placed her hand on her chest. She giggled again. “Am I supposed to be feeling something, Phainon?”

“No! It’s just a small gesture. Now, open your eyes and see what I’ve given you.”

He smirked when she saw him slowly open her hand and chuckled under his breath when her eyes widened. In her palm was a hair clip. A simple yet beautiful thing. A gold diamond with two white petals made of soft fabric pinned at the top, fluttering in the wind. He made the petals and painstakingly carved out the diamond and asked his mother to stitch them together. He was very proud of the result.

And seeing Cyrene’s surprised look made him feel even prouder.

“You,” she started to say, opening and closing her mouth. Her blue eyes met his own. “Phainon, this looks so pretty! I can’t believe you made this all on your own. How long did you spend working on this?”

“About a week,” Phainon replied. “It took some time to get the shape of the petals right. I thought I was about to run out of fabric by the time I was done. The pin was actually the

easiest to make. Well, ok, I didn't make it. I took it from my mother's box of charms, but enough of my rambling, what do you think?"

Phainon waited for her response, hesitating when she didn't say anything. Panic started to set in. Did she like it? She said it was beautiful. What if she just said that to make him happy? Was this a good idea? He didn't make her unhappy, did he?

Before he started to spiral and jump down into yet another rabbit hole, Cyrene pulled him into a hug, the clip still in her hand. Phainon tried to raise his head, but he found he couldn't do so. "Er, Cyrene…?"

"I can hear your thoughts from here," Cyrene hummed, hugging him tighter. "You are quite the overthinker, aren't you, my dear Deliverer?"

"I was hoping you'd say something," Phainon muttered. "I thought you didn't like it."

"Relax! I love it. It was…it was very thoughtful of you. I'll wear it every day."

"Ok, you don't have to do that! *"*

"Well, I want to," said Cyrene, pulling them apart. Her right hand was resting on his shoulder.

She flicked her eyes toward the pin, wordlessly gesturing to him. "Now, if I'm to keep up my promise, I'm going to need some help pinning it to my hair."

She wiggled her eyebrows, and for a second Phainon stared at her, dumbfounded. His eyes were probably blown wide before he processed what she said and burst in laughter.

Cyrene raised a brow, mock-glaring at him, though she was starting to laugh too. "What's so funny?"

"No-nothing," Phainon gasped, shaking his head. He took a few breaths and said in a more even tone, "Nothing, Cyrene. Now turn around so I can put this in your hair."

"Alright," she said, tilting her head. Phainon grabbed the pin from her and grabbed a few strands of her hair. Cyrene started to hum a tune under her breath, drumming her fingers on her lap. He stuck his tongue out and once he managed to slide the pin into place and made sure it was secure, he let go.

"All done." Phainon pulled out a mirror. "How does it look?"

Cyrene grabbed the mirror, inspected herself for a few seconds, kept it aside, and pulled him into another hug. Phainon bit his tongue to hold back a scream. "It's beautiful," she whispered. "I promise I'll always wear this until I am called to the Sea of Souls."

"Woah, uhm," Phainon sputtered, pulling back, feeling his cheeks heating up, "I appreciate that you like it and all, but it's like I said before-you don't have to wear it every day."

“But I want to,” said Cyrene. “You spent days working on it. It’d be most disrespectful if I don’t wear it. And thank you, Phainon. Thank you so much.”

“Heh, you’re welcome.”

“Now then, why don’t you say we go chase some fairies and enact some scenes from a book I borrowed yesterday from the library? We’ll call the others too.”

“Yes!”

The two children giggled, not knowing that that was going to be the last day they’d ever be together. The last day of peace, before the sun turned red and darkness swept the land.

“Oh, Cyrene,” Phainon whispered, his sobs beginning to quiet. His best friend. The girl he loved and cherished the most. His pillar. If only he hadn’t been powerless that day, he could’ve saved her. He could’ve saved his mom, his dad. He could’ve saved everyone.

What a Deliverer he was. He didn’t deserve the title. He didn’t deserve anything- companionship, kindness.

Love.

He didn’t deserve to live. Fate was cruel to let him live while everyone burned all around him.

Yet, here he was, destined to bear Kephale’s Core Flame. Destined to carry the world upon his shoulders, just like the World-Bearing Titan, without asking any questions. It wasn’t just his destiny, it was his duty.

Hah, fate really was cruel.

But now, he needed to get that clip from Mydei. The urge to hold it in his arms and hug it like it was some huge Chimera plushie was strong.

He sniffed, wiped his eyes, and was about to get up before he felt something warm wrap around him. Not burning like the sun, but gentle like a campfire. His head was tucked into the crook of someone’s neck, and he was being rocked back and forth. He didn’t want to open his eyes, he was scared of what he might see. But then he heard someone whisper something in his ear. He couldn’t make out everything that was said, except for the very last line. The last string of words resonated deep within him, and once it registered, he started to sob again, softer now, and nestled closer into the warmth that was so inviting. Into the warmth that invited him with open arms.

To say Mydei started to panic was an understatement. He expected Phainon’s reaction, but he didn’t think he'd react *that badly!*

One moment he was fine (or as fine as he could be), and the next he was a sobbing mess on the floor, yelling gibberish. All because of the clip in his hand that confirmed his suspicions.

This was no ordinary clip, and the memories he saw were enough evidence to point to the owner of it.

“Phainon!” He called, running up to the broken man and faltering a bit in his steps. How should he approach this? If he made any sudden movements, he’d startle the man further. He had to walk up to him slowly. What about touching him? Should he…

Ugh, *fuck it.* He always acted on his instincts and he wasn’t going to stop now.

Mydei crouched and crept up slowly. One wrong move and there was no telling what the Deliverer might do. He had to stay calm- for Phainon’s sake.

He placed an arm on Phainon’s shoulder and gently squeezed it. When he didn’t react, he pulled him into a hug, tucking his head under his chin. “Hey, Phainon?”

No response. Well, that was to be expected.

His body shook in his arms, and it hurt. It hurt so much to see him like this. Phainon was a ray of sunshine, a beacon of hope who always had a smile on his face. A kind-hearted soul who helped everyone in the Holy City. To see him like this now… Mydei had to calm him down. And the best way to calm him down was to talk to him.

“Phainon. I don’t know if you can hear me, but I need you to listen to me, please. I…I have some things to tell you.

“First of all, I’m so sorry for what I did. I didn’t know it was Cyrene’s pin. If I had known, I would’ve waited to give it back to you. I hope you can forgive me.

“I understand your grief. I understand it better than you realize. A home destroyed, comrades gone forever. You lost everything that meant the world to you, and I did as well. You couldn’t save them, and neither could I save my people. Let it all out, Phainon. Shed your grief. Mourn properly, for all tears are not a sign of weakness.”

Phainon’s sobs started to quiet down again, and Mydei smiled–it was working! He was getting to him. At least, he thinks he is.

You’re strong, Phainon. Stronger and braver than you realize. You’ve faced so much and came out standing when most would have fallen. Remember, Aedes Elysiae will never be forgotten as long as you’re still here. Everyone- your friends, your family, they all live in your hearts. They’ll always be a part of you, just like how *we* will always be here for you. Aglaea, Lady Tribbie and Trinnon, Castorice, Hyacine, even that scholar Anaxa. Me as well. You will never have to be alone.”

“Then, in a small act of boldness—if it could even be called that—he leaned forward and whispered into his ear, "I’m proud of you. And I know Cyrene would be proud if she could see the man you’ve become today. Everything you’ve done was not in vain.”

Mydei heard Phainon gasp, and all of a sudden, he felt a weird pressure on his chest. Phainon’s chin was resting there, eyes wide open, and quite red and puffy. He placed a hand

under his chin and let his thumb graze his cheek. “Mydei?” he rasped.

“I’m here.” He tucked his head back to its usual resting spot. “I won’t let you go.”

“Thank you,” Phainon whispered. “I…Can you please…”

Mydei didn’t have to say anything and handed the clip to Phainon, who gripped it with such force his knuckles were slowly turning red. Mydei reached out and rubbed the spot gently. “Hey, don’t do that,” he said, his voice low.

“I’m worried that it might disappear under my palms.”

“It won’t. I can guarantee that.”

“But still.” He snuggled further. “I guess you recognize this.”

“It took me a while,” Mydei admitted. “My mind was eating me away. It was only after your outburst did I realize it belonged to Cyrene. The hair should’ve been a dead giveaway for me.”

Phainon laughed dryly. “At least you remembered. If you’re curious to know, I was the one who made this.”

Mydei felt his jaw slacken. Phainon cackled. “Wait, so it was *you!?* ”

“Surprised, Your Highness?”

“You can’t even fasten your cloak without looking like you fought it and lost. Since when did you have such nimble fingers?”

“I admit I’m a bit rusty now,” Phainon said, chuckling. “But I did have an eye for jewelry. It’s all thanks to my mom, really. She had a bunch of stuff in her room. Despite living in a village, we weren’t in complete misery. It took me a long time to make it. My mom offered to help, but being the stubborn child I was, I kept refusing. Maybe if I had, I would’ve finished it a whole lot sooner.”

“You’re *still* stubborn at times,” Mydei retorted.

Phainon rolled his eyes. “Look who’s calling the kettle black. Also, I never said I wasn’t stubborn.”

“Well then, let me rephrase that-you’re more stubborn than I.”

“Now *that’s* a lie, Mydei, and I can list a few examples. For instance, back at Maemoreal Market-”

“Ack! Ok, shut up and cry Deliverer,” Mydei groaned, shoving his palm into his face. Phainon cackled, hiding his face in his chiton. He sighed and stroked his hair. “But, putting aside everything we just said now, I meant everything I said before. I don’t think you’ll

understand it now-you *never* do, but I hope one day it finally clicks in that pretty little brain of yours."

"So you *do* think I'm pretty."

"Ugh, shut up! Why do I even bother with you?"

"Because you love me🎶."

"Unfortunately," Mydei sighed. "So, what do you want to do? Do you want to leave and go back to Okhema or stay here for a bit?"

Phainon hummed and tightened his hold on him. He closed his eyes and uttered, "Stay here. I don't think I'm strong enough to stand at the moment."

"You know, I could carry you back."

"You'd actually do that for me?"

"No."

"You're no fun."

"But I could make a throne using my blood crystals and add some wheels."

"Your Highness-"

"Phainon."

"Your Royal Pompousness! How do you even sit on that thing? It's uncomfortable as fuck."

"You're such a brat."

"I'm your brat."

"A tragedy indeed."

"Mydei?"

"Yes?"

"Thank you," Phainon said, locking eyes with Mydei and smiling. "I don't think I would've even come here if it weren't for you. Coming back here alone…I know I'd lose myself in my grief. I'm grateful that you're my anchor."

Mydei huffed and looked away, his ears burning, but deep down he was practically glowing at Phainon's words. Of course, being the prideful demi-god he is, he'd never admit it.

But.

One day.

“You’re such a sappy idiot.”

Phainon laughed and didn’t say anything more. After all, there wasn’t anything that needed to be said now. They had each other, broken, but healing.

They’d never be the same, Phainon especially. Mydei knows he can’t always be there for him, that’s why he asked Chartonus to look after him. But, after witnessing what happened today, he figured it’d be best to come back once in a while, or at least text him during his few moments of rest.

For now, he’ll continue to hold him as he sheds away the remaining tears. He made a promise to never leave Phainon, and he intended to keep it.

(And in the after hours of Amphoreus’ Golden Age, in the ruins of the Capital of Might stood a King and a Black Robed Warrior. Golden ichor was spilt everywhere, pooling from the gaping wound where a sword laid buried deep in the king's chest. The swordmaster sobbed, cradling the man’s body as tears fell onto his face. His mask lay discarded near his feet. “Why,” he cried, his voice echoing off the walls. “Why does it have to end like this?”

“Because,” the king replied, weakly lifting his arm to caress his cheek, “That is our fate. It… cannot be changed. Thank you for putting me out of…my misery.”

The swordmaster wept terribly as the light faded from the king's eyes, knowing that Thanatos had finally accepted his beloved. Knowing he’d finally be able to rest in peace.)

Chapter End Notes

Once again, thank you so much for reading this!!

Extra Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> EXTRA CHAPTER!!! I know some of you guys wanted some behind-the-scenes, so here's behind-the-scene no 1!
>
> It's the infamous cooking scene lmao

"Oh fuck."

"Oh, oh shit oh shit oh shit *it's scorching!*"

"Uhhh, is it supposed to be like that?"

Phainon yelped as the pancake flew out of the pan and straight into the garbage bin, like the universe was giving him a sign to quit while he was at it. It was taunting him, whispering in its eerie voice that there was no way he'd be able to make a wonderful, delicious, and mouth-watering dish for the man he cared about.

If slamming his head into the wall would knock him out and end the chaos, he was about two seconds from trying it.

Propped up against the wall on the counter was the cookbook that the Chrysos Heirs used to cook their meals. Surprisingly (but not really), the book belonged to Mydei, who wrote down all the recipes he learned from his time leading the Kremnoan Detachment, bound the pages together, and stored them in the private kitchen for the Heirs to use. Over time, the others added their own recipes on the blank pages the prince left for them to scribble on.

And the recipes were admittedly good. Aglaea, Lady Tribbie, Trianne, and Trinnon had come up with a whole collection of oatmeal-based dishes that Phainon had initially assumed would be soggy and unappetizing, but they turned out to be anything but. Hyacine had also compiled a set of healthy meals packed with vegetables, proteins, and fiber that were perfect for days when no one felt like cooking anything extravagant. Castorice's recipes were more on the simpler side, but they were just as enjoyable. As for Phainon, well...

He was-

"OH ***FUCK OH SHIT AHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHH!!!***"

Phainon screamed like a banshee as he hurled the now-smoking pan into the sink, while trying not to scorch his fingers accidentally. He slammed the tap on full blast, muttering something about how battling Titankin was far better than mixing a bunch of random stuff as

the flames hissed in protest. For fuck sake, he was making flipping *pancakes!* And he was following Mydei's recipe to a *T!*

Well, no wonder he was banned from the kitchen. He couldn't even boil milk to save his life.

The last time he had been in here, he had tried to make a simple sandwich he could munch on after his spar, and that ended... disastrous, to say the least. After Aglaea saw the mess (she was alerted by the strong sense of something *burning*), she permanently banned him from ever entering the kitchen *unless* there was someone in there to supervise him.

It was a good thing no one decided to stop by to grab a snack, lest he be murdered and prematurely end the Flame Chase Journey, and knowing Aglaea, she'd probably prefer sacrificing the entire journey over letting him ruin another frying pan.

Great, Mydei was going to be here in an hour or two, and he had only a single pancake that looked edible on the plate, batter covering almost every inch of the kitchen, the sink overfilling with burnt kitchenware, and scorched pancakes all over the floor and ceiling. He had to make two stacks of pancakes *and* clean the mess he made before anyone saw him.

Argh

The things he does for love. Mydei better appreciate his hard work!

Extra Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Extra scene no 2! This time from Mydei's POV (it connects with Chapter 5)

Also I once again had to use the Yoda speak translator for Chartonus 😭😭

The coast was clear.

No Phainon in sight. Good. At least Mydei didn't have to worry about ducking into suspicious alleyways just to avoid him. He wasn't sure where he was, but oh well, does that matter now?

He walked through the market holding a bunch of parchments in his hand, nodding at those who greeted him and occasionally stopping to smile and ruffle the hair of children who stumbled over in excitement. The Entry Hour was about to pass, and the sun shone over his head. Sometimes, Mydei found himself wondering how summer in Okhema would be if the Dawn Device had a regulator that adjusted both the heat *and* light. But it wasn't like he could walk up to Kephale and demand that, and he was fairly certain the device didn't have any buttons to fiddle with.

Whatever. The weather never bothered him. He has seen worse.

Mydei passed by the Janus Device and strolled into the place he was looking for- Chartonus Smithy.

He booked an appointment with the Mountain-Dweller a while back, and it took a while since both of them were busy with stuff, but they were finally able to settle on a date for Chartonus to take his request. It was also convenient that Phainon happened to be out of town. It seemed the stars were finally aligning in his favor.

Chartonus was busy pounding away on what appeared to be a claymore when Mydei arrived, sweat covering his body from the heat of the flames. Tum and Siskel were standing at the edge of the forge, chatting away with some customers. He checked the time just to make sure he wasn't early or late- 12 pm.

He was right on time.

"Chartonus!" Mydei called out, waving his free hand to catch his attention. The other two Dwellers turned at the sound of his voice, offering small nods of acknowledgment before resuming their conversation. Chartonus paused mid-swing, the hammer still raised in his hand, and looked up with a grunt. "Prince Mydeimos. Came on time, you did. You'd be late, I thought."

"Since when was I ever late?" asked Mydei with a smirk. He was the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos. He was never late for anything. "Are you busy right now?"

"Almost finished with this weapon, I am," Chartonus said, gesturing at the blade. "Done I once am, with your commission, we shall begin. Bring any designs, did you?"

Mydei placed the parchments on the free table. "They're right here. Took me a while to settle on how I wanted them to look, bit I think the overall design came out well."

"Them?" Chartonus tilted his head.

"Ahh." How did Mydei forget to tell him when they last met? "Yeah. Apologies for not telling you earlier, it slipped my mind, but I want you to forge two weapons this time. Is that ok with you? I can pay double if needed."

Chartonus pounded the claymore one last time before setting it and his hammer aside to look at the blueprint. He grabbed the nearest one, unfurled it, and without even taking a proper look at it, he blurted out, "This weapon is for you, not, is it?"

He showed the parchment to Mydei, who barked out a laugh. Of course, a master blacksmith such as himself would be able to find out. "Sharp eyes, Chartonus. You'd be right- it isn't for me. And since you got that right, can you guess who it's for?"

"Easy to figure out, that is, for dressed to reflect the sun, who else in Okhema is? And I know for a fact you would commission a weapon for just anyone, not Prince Mydeimos."

So, even Chartonus figured it out. Well, no matter. "Check out the other design."

And check he did. Chartonus took his time examining every detail, occasionally jotting notes in the margins. They went back and forth over the design, starting with the bow, adjusting its curvature, grip, and draw weight—before moving on to the sword, where the discussion got even more intense.

"You add a moon want to?"

“His sword and the bow are already sun-themed,” Mydei replied with a shrug. “I thought something contrasting might give it more… balance.”

By the time they were finished, Action Hour was well underway, and the streets buzzed with activity. People clustered outside restaurants, enjoying lunch under the open sky, the scent of grilled meats and spiced vegetables drifting through the air. Mydei’s stomach gave a quiet grumble—he was definitely getting hungry. He was willing to bet Chartonus was, too. It was time to wrap this up.

He gave the blueprints one last satisfied nod and slid them across the table, along with a pouch. "I guess that'll be all then. I'll leave the rest to your magic, Chartonus."

"Start working on these as soon as I can, I will," said Chartonus, grabbing the paper and taking it inside. "By when do you need them?"

"Finish them at your own pace and let me know a week in advance. I'll find a way to evade Phainon... somehow."

"Sounds good. In that case, you later, Prince Mydeimos, I shall see."

"I'll see you later too, Chartonus."

And with that, Mydei all but ran to the nearest restaurant to munch on some meat and honey cakes.

Extra Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

> EXTRA SCENE 3! This time featuring my bubblegum girlie HYACINE! She is like me fr
>
> Also, smoll announcement: I'M GONNA WORK ON ANOTHER 5+1 FIC (This time primarily focusing on Phainon's POV)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Hyacine sighed, tossing and turning restlessly on her bed. The wind blew gently through her open window, cooling the room with a soft breeze. Her hair, no longer tied in its usual pigtails, was strewn across the pillow in loose waves. Her uniform lay crumpled over the back of a chair, replaced now by a set of loose-fitting pajamas that hung comfortably on her frame. Beside her rested Ica, who was snoring softly and letting out little chirps that would normally make her giggle. Not today, sadly.

How long has it been since she, De, and the soldiers returned from their expedition? One? Two? Even three? She was supposed to be back at the Grove, writing down a report for the Twilight Courtyard and telling Professor Anaxa about the whole ordeal, but she couldn't find it in herself to get up. Her body was still smarting from healing so many people at once. She was banned from entering the infirmary by both Lady Aglaea and Lady Tribbie (apparently under strict orders from De and the two ladies themselves) until she was fully rested and able to stand on her own two feet without collapsing from sheer exhaustion. And...she couldn't find it in herself to argue back.

So, after a short talk with Mydei, she had found herself trudging back to her room and all but collapsed onto the bed. Little Ica fluttered anxiously around her, chirping in concern before finally settling at her side, nuzzling into the crook of her arm, letting out tiny bursts of his healing power. Hyacine smiled and carefully ruffled his mane before pulling him close and drifting off to sleep.

That was hours ago. Now, she was itching to put her hands to good use. Her body was brimming with excess energy she wanted to get rid of eagerly. Bubbles were drifting through the air, emerging from the mini bath, popping as they touched the ceiling. She couldn't just leave her room and go to the sickbay, for she knew Lady Aglaea would undoubtedly be there with her golden threads. In fact, she'd bet her threads should be strung all over her room by now, monitoring her every move like a network of living security cameras.

So *boring!*

Hyacine carefully stood up, careful not to jostle Ica, and covered his tiny body with the cover. If she wasn't allowed to go anywhere that required using her powers, she might as well go outside and get some fresh air. That wasn't a violation of any rules now, was it?

She walked over to her door, slipped on her shoes, and stepped outside, locking it behind her with a soft click. Ica could take care of himself, but she figured it'd be better if he got a few more minutes of rest. He deserved it after all for healing her.

The corridor was long and lit by the warm glow of the Dawn Device, its golden rays streaming through the tall windows and painting soft patterns on the floor. It led straight to the balcony where Hyacine would regularly sit and watch the city go on about their day. She may reside in the courtyard, but Lady Aglaea always wanted her to have a comfortable time when she was in Okhema. Plus, she oftentimes found herself coming back again and again when stress got to her.

She carefully sat down on the recliner and lay down, grabbing a book from the table. A bunch of romance novels that Castorice recommended were on the table- nothing *too* spicy (she'd rather take on the Black Tide herself instead of reading two people doing the goddamn *tango!*) but something to keep her entertained. The book she snagged looked like it was on the more comedic side. It was titled *'How to Hate You (And Fail Miserably).'*

'Why does it remind me of two people..." Hyacine murmured, then shrugged her shoulders, brushing the thought aside. She was pretty sure it was just a coincidence.

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Ok, it was *not* a coincidence. It certainly was *not a coincidence!*

It looked like whoever wrote this had Snowy and De in mind because the characters sounded *exactly* like them. No changes, no embellishments, nothing whatsoever. Now that Hyacine thought about it... did that count as copyright infringement?

Well, at least she was kicking her feet and squealing in joy. And she immediately got up to lock the balcony door. If she was going to read this, it's best to do it in secret...and maybe hunt down the author and ask for more.

It'll be her little secret. And Ica's.

Chapter End Notes

And she immediately asks Castorice to write something about the two for her to read every day. Btw ICA LOOKS SO ADORABLE AHHHH I NEED AN ICA PLUSHIE STAT!!

This may be the last extra chap (unless I get another idea)

Extra Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> OK I SWEAR THIS IS THE LAST CHAPTER BEFORE I START BRAINSTORMING IDEAS FOR THE NEXT 5+1 FIC But i felt like I had to end this with those two idiots cause... ya know... its them... (ensues gremlin laugh)
>
> Anyways TYSM FOR ALL THE KUDOS AND COMMENTS ON THIS DUM LIL THING I'M SO HAPPY YOU LOVED THIS FIC! I certainly had a fun time writing this! Here's to more fics about our two warriors!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The scent of metal hung heavy in the air as Okhema's two greatest warriors clashed in the training field, trading blow after blow under the morning sun. The sharp ring of Phainon's sword striking against Mydei's gauntlets reverberated across the stone walls like thunder cracking through a battlefield.

The soldiers from the Kremnoan Detachment watched with bated breath, eagerly cheering on their Crowned Prince and their Deliverer as their duel raged on. Mydei was quietly glad to see how they'd warmed up to Phainon over the years- sparring with him on occasion, and even helping the younger recruits with their swordplay. There was a time when he was worried if he had made the wrong move when he brought his people to the Holy City, but seeing how far they've come, he was proud.

Usually, when he and Phainon had one of their sparring sessions, they'd clear the arena lest they accidentally hurt someone, but the youngsters practically begged both of them to watch, claiming that they'd learn faster and better if they saw the 'pros' fighting. It just so happened that the other members of the detachment were conveniently at the baths at the time and overheard what the kids were saying. It didn't take long before they joined in, begging the youngsters as well.

At first, Mydei got a bit frustrated and pinched the bridge of his nose, fully prepared to lecture them. They all knew how intense his and Phainon's spars could get, and he didn't want anyone standing too close. He wasn't about to risk someone getting hurt just because they wanted front-row seats to a *brawl*.

Phainon, however, had merely shrugged and said, *"Why not?"* in the most infuriatingly casual tone imaginable, and it almost sent Mydei into a fit right then and there. He was *this* close to punching the Deliverer in the face and threatening him with a duel ban until he shot him those goddamn *puppy eyes* that made everyone's knees weak, and he found himself reluctantly agreeing. At least the children were happy after that.

(He still punched Phainon in the stomach after they left.)

Now, he was focused on beating the idiot, taking the offensive and pushing him into a corner. Phainon was aggressive, more so than usual and met every strike with fierce, unrelenting force. At one point, Phainon nearly sent him tumbling with a well-placed blow, and Mydei only managed to stay upright by planting his feet and digging his heel into the ground. Was it because of the crowd? He wasn't sure.

Regardless, it had been nearly three hours, and it was almost time for lunch. The restaurant they usually went to ran out of their honey cakes fast, and Mydei was not having it-he was going to do whatever it took to end this battle as fast as he could so he could drag his sorry ass and make him buy his favorite pastry and the entirety of their lunch (well, that was their bet this time.)

So, he shifted, exposing his side, and just as he predicted, Phainon saw the opening and lunged straight for him...

Only for Mydei to slam his elbow into Phainon’s back, knocking him to the ground with a thud. He barely gave him a second to recover as he towered over him, grabbed the sword before Phainon could, and pressed the blade near his throat.

The crowd went silent, save for their heavy breathing. The light from the Dawn Device shone overhead, casting long shadows across the arena floor and glinting off the steel of their weapons. Sweat drenched them both, soaking their clothes and clinging to their skin. Mydei leaned until he was at eye level and whispered into his ear, "Do you yield?"

Phainon huffed. "If I gave up now, this would be the shortest spar we’ve ever had. I’d be disgracing our ten-day-long battle."

"You'd only be disgracing it if I say so," Mydei replied, and stepped aside and held out his hand. "And I say you aren't. So don't worry your pretty little head over it, Phainon. You did well."

Mydei pulled him to his feet, and the crowd around them erupted into cheers and applause. Phainon giggled, brushing off the dust as he let go of Mydei’s hand and gave an exaggerated bow to their audience, causing him to roll his eyes. Ever the showman that stupid Deliverer...

Unfortunately, it was the same man he liked.

So, without further warning, he grabbed Phainon's arm and dragged him to the baths, ignoring his excessive whining. They still had to wash themselves before heading for lunch, and he was hungry as hell.

Chapter End Notes

Once again, from the bottom of my heart, I LUV YOU ALLLLLLL ❤️

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